Collins COBUILD English Grammar, 4the edition (2017)

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0.1 About COBUILD

When the 1st COBUILD dictionary was published in 1987, it revolutionized dictionaries for learners.

It was the 1st of the new generation of language reference materials that were based on actual evidence of how English was used, rather than lexicographer intuition.

Collins and the University of Birmingham, led by the linguist John Sinclair, developed an electronic corpus in 1980s, called the Collins Birmingham University International Language Database (COBUILD).

This corpus, which for several years was known as the Bank of English©, became the largest collection of English data in the world.

COBUILD dictionary editors use the corpus to analyze the way that people really use the language.

The Collins Corpus now contains 4.5 billion words taken from websites, newspapers, magazines and books published around the world, and from spoken material from radio, TV and everyday conversations.

New data is added to the corpus every month, to help COBUILD editors identify new words, grammatical structures, and meanings from the moment they are 1st used.

All COBUILD language reference books are based on the information their editors find the Collins Corpus.

Because the corpus is so large, their editors can look at lots of examples of how people really use the language.

The data tells them how the language is used; the function of different structures; which words are used together; and how often these words and structures are used.

All of the examples in COBUILD language materials are examples of real English, taken from the corpus.

The examples have been carefully chosen to demonstrate typical grammatical patterns, typically vocabulary and typical contexts.

COBUILD English Grammar is no exception: Collins editors and researchers have been able to use this wealthy of information to establish a unique and full description of English grammar, and to track the development of certain grammatical structures over time.

The corpus lies at the heart of COBUILD, and you can be confident that COBUILD will show you what you need to know to be able to communicate easily and accurately in English.

To learn more about COBUILD and the Collins Corpus, go to www.collinselt.com and click on 'COBUILD Reference'.

0.2 Introduction

This grammar is suitable for anyone who is interested in the English language and how it works in everyday current contexts.

It has been written mainly for advanced-level students and their teachers, but any serious learner will find it a valuable reference tool.

The information in this book is taken from a long and careful study of present-day English involving the analysis of the Collins Corpus - a corpus of many millions of words of speech and writing.

0.2.1 A functional approach

Most people who study and use a language are interested in how they can *do things* with the language - how they can make meanings, get attention, influence people, and learn about the world.

They are interested in the grammatical structure of the language as a way of getting things done.

A grammar that puts together the patterns of the language and the things you can do with them is called a *functional grammar*.

This is a functional grammar; that is to say, it is based on the important relation between structure and function.

Each chapter is built around a major function of language, e.g. *describing people and things*, and *reporting what someone said*.

Each of these functions is regularly expressed in English by particular structures.

E.g., describing people and things is usually expressed by adjectives, and reporting what people say or think typically involves a reporting verb e.g. *say*, followed by a clause beginning with *that* or a clause with quotation marks (' ') around it.

This grammar follows up each major statement (often called a *rule* in other grammars) with a detailed description of the uses surrounding it - including any exceptions.

The scope of the original function may then be extended.

E.g., the basic, central function of reporting verbs (Chap. 7) is to state what someone has said.

Example 0.2.1. *He said he would be back soon.*

It can be easily be extended to include what someone has written.

Example 0.2.2. *His mother wrote that he had finally arrived home.*

Then it can be widened to include thoughts and feelings; these do not need to be expressed in words, but the reporting structure is very convenient.

Example 0.2.3. *The boys thought he was dead.*

From this we can see the reporting clause as a more general way of introducing another clause.

Examples

All the examples in this book are taken from the Collins Corpus.

As ever, the corpus lies at the heart of each grammar point described, helping compilers to make confident and accurate decisions about different structures and usage.

Examples themselves remain close to the corpus, with minor changes made so that they are more accessible to the learner.

They are carefully chosen so as to illustrate typical patterns and collocations in real-life situations.

0.2.2 Groups of words that behave in the same way

As well as providing a wealth of illustrative examples, this book gives further information about the grammar of a large number of specific words.

The actual words and phrases that are regularly used in each structure are given in a series of lists.

In this way, the learner can get a good idea of how large or small a grammatical class is, and how many words a certain rule applies to.

Wherever there is good reason to do so, the words and phrases are grouped together in a list in a meaningful arrangement.

So, e.g., at [1.21], separate groups are set in a single list, including animals, fish, words ending in *-craft*, and foreign words ending in *-s*.

These all share the same feature, i.e. that they can be either singular or plural nouns without any change in form - *moose, salmon, aircraft, corps*.

From a purely grammatical point of view, they could all go in a single alphabetical list; however from a teaching and learning point of view, it is helpful to have them further classified according to their meaning.

0.2.3 'Be creative'

Certain areas of English grammar are very flexible and *productive*.

Some are well known, e.g. the fact that almost any noun in English can modify another noun.

E.g., the noun *steam* can be used in, among others, the following combinations: *steam bath, steam room, steam engine, steam iron, steam power*, and *steam train*.

With this in mind, several 'Be creative' features are included to encourage learners to use their imagination, and to be more confident about expressing themselves.

In such cases, rather than giving a definite rule, the authors prefer to give guidance so that the user can make individual choices with no serious risk of error.

By describing the language in this way, give plenty of scope for creativity and innovation.

0.2.4 Accessibility

When using a grammar, it can be difficult to find the information that you want.

This is often the biggest single problem for users of grammars, and a good reason why grammars are often unpopular with learners.

This grammar makes a special effort to support the user.

The authors have aimed to use the most up-to-date and commonly used grammatical terminology throughout.

Technical terms have been used only where there is no obvious alternative.

A glossary of terms is provided and they are also all listed in the index.

There is a contents list at the beginning of the book, and there is an individual contents list at the beginning of each chapter.

Using these of the index, the user will be able to find the section or paragraph where a function is associated with a structure.

Throughout the book there are paragraph headings that show the topic of almost every paragraph, and there are frequent additional headings for each section of a chapter.

At the top of each page, there is another heading to guide the user.

0.2.5 New developments in language

The continued development of the corpus enables us to keep us with the ever-changing nature of language.

At COBUILD, the authorscontinually track and research the development of grammatical features, e.g.:

(i) the use of the progressive with so-called stative verbs (e.g. *I'm loving every minute of it*)

(ii) the use of *much* in affirmative unmodified statements (e.g. *There was much debate*)

(iii) the spread of generic pronouns (e.g. *You get some people who are very difficult*)

(iv) the use of *like* in reporting structures (e.g. *And I was like, 'wow!'*)

(v) the use of all-purpose question tags in some varieties of spoken informal English (e.g. *innit*)

The results are often fascinating and surprising, and enable us to ensure that each new edition of the Grammar gives you a clear portrayal of real English as it is written and spoken today.

0.2.6 The grammar of business & academic English

An extension of our functional approach has been to focus on 2 main contexts in which English is used as a lingua franca throughout the world - business and academic English.

As a result, 2 supplementary sections identify the principal areas of grammar that learners need to master if they wish to communicate effectively in business and academic contexts.

The section on the grammar of business English looks at typical structures used in such contexts as sharing information, negotiating, and giving presentations.

The academic English section covers such areas as explaining results, reviewing research, and reporting findings.

Extensive cross-referencing allows the user to refer back to the main text, where structures are discussed in greater detail.

The authors hope that you will enjoy learning about English grammar from a functional perspective - from exploring the wealth of real-world examples of current language, to understanding how certain structures work in business and academic contexts.

The authors hope, too, that as a result, you will gain the confidence to use English creatively and effectively in a wide range of everyday situations.

0.2.7 Getting the most out of COBUILD English Grammar

Would you like to discover more about the wealth of information COBUILD English Grammar has to offer, and explore the subject of grammar further?

If so, go to `www.collinselt.com/cobuildenglishgrammar`, where you will find a range of blogposts, written by experts in the field, that encourage focused thinking and discussion with your peers on a variety of topics, e.g.:

- questioning traditionally accepted grammar 'rules'
- establishing the difference between nonstandard usage and errors
- thinking about why some people avoid using the word 'tense' to talk about perfect and progressive forms.

To help you examine each topic in turn in greater detail, each blogpost has a link to a corresponding worksheet.

0.3 How to use this Grammar

The COBUILD English Grammar is designed to be used both for quick reference and for in-depth study.

0.3.1 Organization of the main text

The main text of the Grammar is divided into 10 chapters.

The 1st 2 chapters deal with the noun phrase, Chaps. 3–5 with the verb phrase.

Chap. 6 deals with adverbs and prepositions, Chap. 7 with reporting, Chap. 8 with joining words, phrases and clauses, and Chaps. 9–10 with continuous text.

Each chapter consists of a series of main topics and each topic is divided into sections.

Paragraphs in the chapter are numbered, so that Chap. 1 runs from **1.1** to **1.251**, Chap. 2 from **2.1** to **2.302** and so on.

This numbering system makes it easy for the user to refer to different but related points.

There are cross-references throughout the text, either pointing to the main place where a topic is dealt with or to another paragraph where more information is given.

Most paragraphs also have a heading, saying in a few words what it deals with, especially which grammatical structure is being explained.

Some paragraph headings do not show specifically what the paragraph deals with, but indicate information of a different kind.

These paragraphs have the headings 'Be careful,' 'Be Creative', and 'Usage Note'.

[!] 'Be Careful' highlights points where people often have problems with a particular grammatical feature of English, e.g. because it is a feature where English is different from many other languages.

[⋆] 'Be Creative' indicates that the rule that has been mentioned can be applied in English to a very large number of words.

E.g., it is nearly always possible to make the *-ing* participle of a verb into an adjective that is used in front of a noun.

By taking note of these features, you can use the rules that have been presented in a creative and original way, giving you greater freedom to express yourself in English.

'Be Creative' features are explained in greater detail in the Introduction.

[i] 'Usage Note' gives information about the use of individual words or small groups of words.

This information is important but cannot be generalized into a grammatical rule.

The Usage Notes help you to understand points that are important for the understanding of particular words, rather than points that relate to large numbers of words.

The U.S. flag symbol highlights paragraphs containing information about typical American English usage.

The speech bubble symbol identifies paragraphs describing structures that are most commonly found in spoken English.

Most of the grammatical explanations are followed by examples showing how the structure is used.

These examples are all taken from the Collins Corpus, and show how the structures are used naturally in speech or writing.

The examples therefore give important information about typical use of a structure, the words it is frequently used with, and the contexts in which it is likely to occur.

Throughout the book, grammatical explanations are followed by lists of the words that typically illustrate that grammatical point.

E.g., in Chap. 3, the point is made that many verbs can be either transitive or intransitive with the same meaning.

This is followed by a list of verbs that are frequently used in this way.

The lists go beyond the actual examples of use that are given, to other words that behave in similar ways.

They show whether the point being made can be applied to a small number or a large number of words.

If the group is small, all members of it are given.

If the group is large, then the most frequently used words are given.

These lists can be used to help you increase your vocabulary and to check that you are using newly learned English words correctly.

0.3.2 Additional contents

In addition to the main text, various other sections are included to help you to get the most out of this Grammar.

These additional sections are described below.

0.3.2.1 Glossary of grammatical terms

The Glossary explains the meaning of grammatical terms.

It covers the terms that are used in this grammar, and also includes terms that are used in other grammars, with a cross-reference to the term used in this book, where appropriate.

E.g., this grammar talks about the *present progressive*, whereas some other grammars call it the *present continuous*.

Both of these terms are mentioned in the Glossary, with the explanation being given at *present progressive*.

0.3.2.2 Reference section

This section at the back of the book provides an easy-to-use reference guide that shows how the following groups of words are formed:

- plurals of nouns
- the comparative and superlative of adjectives
- '-ly' adverbs formed from adjectives

- the comparative and superlative of adverbs
- tenses
- other verb forms
- passives
- principal parts of irregular verbs

The Reference section also includes other topics.

E.g., it starts with a pronunciation guide, to remind you of the sounds of English.

There are also lists of numbers, and an explanation of how numbers are expressed aloud.

0.3.2.3 The grammar of business & academic English

These sections provide key guidance in the principal areas of grammar that learners need to master for effective communication in business and academic contexts.

0.3.2.4 Index

The Index is a comprehensive list of everything dealt with in the Grammar.

It covers:

- the grammatical and functional topics dealt with in the Grammar;
- individual words which are used as examples of a particular grammatical point;
- grammatical terms, both those used in this book and those commonly used in other books.

0.4 Glossary of grammatical terms

1. **abstract noun**: a noun used to describe a quality, idea, or experience rather than something physical or concrete; e.g., *joy, size, language.*

   Cf. **concrete noun**.

2. **active**: used for describing verb phrases e.g. *gives*, and *has made*, where the subject is the person or thing doing the action or responsible for the action.

   Cf. **passive**.

3. **adjectival clause**: another name for **relative clause**.

4. **adjective**: a word used to tell yu more about a thing, e.g. its appearance, color, size, or other qualities; e.g., ... *a pretty blue dress.*

5. **adverb**: a word that gives more information about when, how, where, or in what circumstances something happens; e.g. *quickly, now.*

   There are several different kinds of adverb; adverbs of degree, manner, place, time, duration, and frequency.

   There are also **focusing adverbs**.

6. **adverbial**: a word or combination of words added to a clause to give more information about time, place, or manner.

   See also **sentence adverbial** and **sentence connector**.

7. **adverb of degree**: an adverb indicating the amount or extent of a feeling or quality; e.g. *extremely.*

8. **adverb/adverbial of duration**: an adverb or adverbial indicating how long something lasts; e.g. *briefly, for a long time.*

9. **adverb/adverbial of frequency**: an adverb or adverbial indicating how often something happens; e.g. *often, once a week.*

10. **adverb of manner**: an adverb indicating the way in which something happens or is done; e.g. *carefully.*

11. **adverb of place**: an adverb that gives more information about position or direction; e.g. *Move closer.*

12. **adverb particle**: an adverb used as part of a phrasal verb; e.g. *hide out, sit up, turn round*.

13. **affirmative**: not containing a negative word.

    Also called **positive**.

14. **agent**: another name for **performer**.

15. **agreement**: the relationship between a subject and its verb, or between a number or determiner and its noun; e.g. *I look/she looks... 1 bell/3 bells*.

    Also called **concord**.

16. **apostrophe s**: an ending ('s) added to a noun to mark possession; e.g. ... *Harriet's daughter... the professor's husband... the Managing Director's secretary*.

17. **article**: see **definite article**, **indefinite article**.

18. **aspect**: the use of verb forms to show whether an action is continuing, repeated, or finished.

19. **attributive**: used for describing the position of adjectives when they are used in front of a noun.

    Cf. **predicative**.

20. **auxiliary verb**: 1 of the verbs *be, have*, and *do* when they are used with a main verb to make verb forms, negatives, questions, and so on.

    Also called **auxiliary**.

    Modals are also auxiliary verbs.

21. **bare infinitive**: another name for **infinitive without to**.

22. **base form**: the form of a verb that has no letters added to the end and is not a past form; e.g. *walk, go, have, be*.

    The base form is the form you look up in a dictionary.

23. **broad negative**: 1 of a small group of adverbs including *barely* and *seldom* which are used to make a statement almost negative; e.g. *I barely knew her*.

24. **cardinal number**: a number used for counting; e.g. *one, seven, nineteen*.

25. **classifying adjective**: an adjective used to identity something as being of particular type; e.g. *Indian, wooden, mental*.

    They do not have comparatives or superlatives.

    Cf. **qualitative adjective**.

26. **clause**: a group of words containing a verb.

    See also **main clause** and **subordinate clause**.

27. **clause of manner**: a subordinate clause that describes the way in which something is done, usually introduced with *as* or *like*; e.g. *She talks like her mother used to*.

28. **collective noun**: a noun that refers to a group of people or things; e.g. *committee, team*.

29. **color adjective**: an adjective referring to a color; e.g. *red, blue, scarlet*.

30. **common noun**: a noun used to refer to a person, thing, or substance; e.g. *sailor, computer, glass*.

    Cf. **proper noun**.

31. **comparative**: an adjective or adverb with *-er* on the end or *more* in front of it; e.g. *friendlier, more important, more carefully*.

32. **complement**: a noun phrase or adjective that comes after a linking verb e.g. *be*, and gives more information about the subject or object of the clause; e.g. *She is a teacher, She is tired, They made her chairperson*.

33. **complex sentence**: a sentence consisting of 2 or more main clauses linked by a subordinating conjunction; e.g. *We went inside when it started to rain*.

34. **compound**: a combination of 2 or more words functioning as a unit.

    E.g., *self-centered* and *free-style* are compound adjectives, *bus stop* and *state of affairs* are compounds nouns, and *dry-clean* and *roller-skate* are compound verbs.

35. **compound sentence**: a sentence consisting of 2 or more main clauses linked by a coordinating conjunction; e.g. *They picked her up and took her into the house.*

36. **concessive clause**: a subordinate clause, usually introduced by *although* or *while*, that contrasts with a main clause; e.g. *Although I like her, I find her hard to talk to.*

37. **concord**: another name for **agreement**.

38. **concrete noun**: a noun that refers to something we can touch or see; e.g. *table, dress, flower.*

    Cf. **abstract noun**.

39. **conditional clause**: a subordinate clause usually starting with *if*.

    The event described in the main clause depends on the condition described in the subordinate clause; e.g. *If it rains, we'll go to the cinema.*

    They would be rich if they had taken my advice.

40. **conjunction**: a word linking together 2 clauses, phrases, or words.

    There are 2 types of conjunction - **coordinating conjunctions**, which link parts of a sentence of the same grammatical type (*and, but, or*), and **subordinating conjunctions**, which begin subordinate clauses (*although, when*).

41. **continuous**: another name for **progressive**.

42. **contraction**: a shortened form in which an auxiliary verb and *not*, or a subject and an auxiliary verb, are joined together and functions as 1 word; e.g. *aren't, she's.*

43. **coordinate clause**: a clause that is connected to another clause with a coordinating conjunction e.g. *and or but*; e.g. *He fell and broke his leg.*

44. **coordinating conjunction**: a word e.g. *and, but*, or *or* which joins together 2 clauses, phrases, or words of the same grammatical type.

45. **copula**: a name sometimes used to refer to the verb *be*.

    In this grammar, the term **linking verb** is used.

46. **countable noun**: a noun that can be singular or plural; e.g. *dog/dogs, lemon/lemons, foot/feet.*

    Also called **count noun**.

47. **declarative**: a clause in the declarative form has the subject followed by the verb.

    Most statements are made in the declarative form.

    Also called **indicative**.

48. **defining non-finite clause**: a participle clause that is placed after a noun phrase to identify the person or thing you are talking about; e.g. *The girl wearing the red hat.*

49. **defining relative clause**: a relative clause that identifies the person or thing that is being talked about; e.g. *I wrote down everything that she said.*

50. **definite article**: the determiner '*the*'.

51. **delexical verb**: a verb that has very little meaning in itself and is used with an object that carries the main meaning of the structure.

    Give, have, and *take* are commonly used as delexical verbs; e.g. *She gave a small cry.*

    I've had a bath.

52. **demonstrative**: 1 of the words *this, that, these*, and *those* used in front of a noun; e.g. ... *this woman... that tree.*

    They are also used as pronouns; e.g. *That looks nice... This is fun.*

53. **dependent clause**: another name for **subordinate clause**.

54. **definite determiner**: 1 of a groups of determiners including *the, that* and *your* which you use when the person you are speaking to understands which person or thing you are talking about; e.g. *the old man, my ideas.*

55. **determiner**: 1 of a group of words including *the, a, some*, and *my* which are used at the beginning of a noun phrase.

56. **direct object**: a noun phrase referring to a person or thing affected by an action, in a sentence with an active verb; e.g. *She wrote her name... I shut the windows.*

57. **direct speech**: speech reported in the words actually spoken by someone, without any changes in tense, person, and so on.

58. **ditransitive verb**: a verb e.g. *give, take*, or *sell* which can have both an indirect and a direct object; e.g. *She gave me a kiss.*

59. **dynamic verb**: a verb e.g. *run, give* or *slice* which describes an action.

    Cf. **stative verb**.

60. ***-ed* adjective**: an adjective that ends in *-ed*, and usually has the same form as the *-ed* participle of a verb, or is formed by adding *-ed* to a noun; e.g. *a worried look... skilled workers.*

    Adjectives that do not end in *-ed* but have the same forms as irregular *-ed* participles are also called *-ed* adjectives; e.g. a *broken* bone.

61. ***-ed* particle**: a verb form e.g. *walked* or *played*, which is used to make perfect forms and passives, or in some cases an adjective.

    Irregular participles e.g. *given* and *broken* are also called *-ed* participles because they behave like regular *-ed* participles.

    Also called **past participle**.

62. **ellipsis**: when you leave out words because they are obvious from the context.

63. **emphasizing adjective**: an adjective e.g. *complete, utter* or *total* which stresses how strongly you feel about something; e.g. *I feel a complete fool.*

64. **ergative verb**: a verb that can be either transitive or intransitive in the same meaning.

    To use the verb intransitively, you use the object of the transitive verb as the subject of the intransitive verb; e.g. *He had boiled a kettle... The kettle had boiled.*

65. **exclamation**: a word or sentence spoken suddenly and loudly in order to express surprise, anger, and so on; e.g. *Oh gosh!*

66. **finite**: a finite verb is inflected according to person or tense rather than being an infinitive or a participle.

67. **first person**: see **person**.

68. **focusing adverb**: a sentence adverb that indicates the most relevant thing involved; e.g. *only, mainly, especially.*

69. **future**: the use of *will* or *shall* with the base form of the verb to refer to future events; e.g. *She will come tomorrow.*

70. **future progressive**: the use of *will be* or *shall be* and an *-ing* participle to refer to future events; e.g. *She will be going soon.*

    Also called **future continuous**.

71. **future perfect**: the use of *will have* or *shall have* and an *-ed* participle to refer to future events; e.g. *I shall have finished tomorrow.*

72. **future perfect progressive**: the use of *will* or *shall* with *have been* and an *-ing* participle to refer to future events; e.g. *I will have been walking for 3 hours by then.*

    Also called **future perfect continuous**.

73. **gender**: a grammatical term referring to the difference between masculine and feminine words e.g. *he* and *she.*

74. **generic pronoun**: 1 of a group of pronouns including *you* and *they* which are used to refer to people in general.

75. **gerund**: another name for ***-ing* noun**.

76. **gradable**: a gradable adjective can be used with a word e.g. *very* to say that the person or thing referred to has more or less of a quantity; e.g. *very boring, less helpful.*

77. **idiom**: a group of 2 or more words with a meaning that cannot be understood by taking the meaning of each individual word; e.g. *to kick the bucket, to run wild.*

78. ***if*-clause**: a **conditional clause**; or a clause used to report a *yes/no*-question.

79. **imperative**: a clause in the imperative has the base form of the verb without a subject, e.g. *Come here... Take 2 tablets every 4 hours... Enjoy yourself.*

80. **impersonal**: ***it*** is an impersonal subject when it is used to introduce a fact, or when it is used in a split sentence; e.g. *It's raining... It was you who asked.*

81. **indefinite article**: the determiners *a* and *an*.

82. **indefinite determiner**: 1 of a group of determiners including *a, many* and *several* which you use to refer to someone or something of a particular type, without saying which person or thing you mean; e.g. *an old man, several suggestions.*

83. **indefinite place adverb**: 1 of a group of adverbs including *anywhere* and *somewhere* which are used to indicate position or location in a general or vague way.

84. **indefinite pronoun**: 1 of a group of pronouns including *someone* and *anything* which are used to refer to a person or thing in a generaly way.

85. **indicative**: another name for **declarative**.

86. **indirect object**: a 2nd object used with a transitive verb to indicate who or what benefits from an action, or gets something as a result of it; e.g. *She gave me a rose.*

87. **indirect question**: a way of asking a question that makes it sound more polite; e.g. *Can you tell me where the bank is?* instead of *Where is the bank?*

88. **indirect speech**: another name for **reported speech**.

89. **infinitive**: the base form of a verb.

    It is often used with *to* in front of it; e.g. *(to) take, (to) see, (to) bring.*

90. **infinitive without to**: the infinitive form without *to* in front of it, used with modals and certain other verbs; e.g. *You must go... Let me think.*

91. **inflection**: the variation in the form of a word to show differences in tense, number, case, and degree.

92. ***-ing* adjective**: an adjective that has the same form as the *-ing* participle of a verb; e.g. *... a smiling face... a winning streak.*

93. ***-ing* participle**: a verb form ending in *-ing* that is used to make verb forms, and as an adjective.

    Also called the **present participle**.

94. ***-ing* noun**: a noun that has the same form as the *-ing* participle of a verb; e.g. *Swimming is good for you.*

95. **interjection**: another name for **exclamation**.

96. **interrogative adverb**: 1 of the adverbs *how, when, where*, and *why* when they are used to ask questions.

97. **interrogative**: a clause in the interrogative form has part or all of the verb phrase in front of the subject.

    Most questions are asked in the interrogative form.

98. **interrogative pronoun**: 1 of the pronouns *who, whose, whom, what*, and *which* when they are used to ask questions.

99. **intransitive verb**: a verb that is used to talk about an action or event that only involves the subject and so does not have an object; e.g. *She arrived... I was yawning.*

100. **inversion**: changing the word order in a sentence, especially changing the order of the subject and the verb.

101. **irregular**: not following the normal rules for inflection.

     An irregular verb has a past form and/or *-ed* participle that is formed in a different way from the regular ending.

102. **lexical verb**: another name for **main verb**.

103. **linking verb**: a verb that links the subject and complement of a clause; e.g. *be, become, seem, appear.*

     Also sometimes called **copula**.

104. **main clause**: a clause that is not dependent on, or is not part of, another clause.

105. **main verb**: any verb that is not an auxiliary verb.

     Also called **lexical verb**.

106. **mass noun**: (in this grammar) a noun that is usually an uncountable noun, but that can be used as a countable noun when it refers to quantities or types of something; e.g. *... 2 sugars... cough medicines.*

107. **measurement noun**: a noun that refers to a unit of size, volume, weight, speed, temperature, etc.: e.g. *mile, liter, degree.*

108. **modal**: an auxiliary verb that is used with a main verb to indicate a particular attitude, e.g. possibility, obligation, prediction, or deduction; e.g. *can, could, may, might.*

     Also called *modal auxiliary* or *modal verb.*

109. **modifier**: a word or group of words that come in front of a noun; e.g. *... a beautiful sunny day... a psychology conference.*

110. **negative**: used for describing a sentence that uses a word like *not, never*, or *no one* to indicate the absence or opposite of something, or to say that something is not the case; e.g. *I don't know you... I'll never forget.*

     The opposite is **affirmative**.

111. **negative word**: a word e.g. *never* and *not* which expresses a negative meaning.

112. **nominal relative clause**: a subordinate clause that functions as a noun and often begins with *what* or *whatever*; e.g. *What he said was true.*

113. **nominal *that*-clause**: a subordinate clause that functions as a noun and begins with *that*; e.g. *He showed that it was true.*

114. **non-defining relative clause**: a relative clause that gives more information about someone or something, but that is not needed to identify them; e.g. *That's Mary, who was at university with me.*

     Cf. **defining relative clause**.

115. **non-finite**: the non-finite forms of a verb are the infinitive and participle forms; e.g. *to take, taking, taken.*

116. **noun**: a word that refers to people, things, and abstract ideas e.g. feelings and qualities; e.g. *woman, Harry, guilt.*

117. **noun phrase**: a group of words that acts as the subject, complement, or object of a clause, or as the object of a preposition.

118. **noun modifier**: a noun used in front of another noun, as if it were an adjective; e.g. *... a car door... a steel works.*

119. **number**: the way in which differences between singular and plural are shown; e.g. *flower/flowers, that/those.*

     See also **cardinal number** and **ordinal number**.

120. **object**: a noun phrase that refers to a person or thing, other than the subject, which is involved in or affected by the action of a verb.

     See also **direct object** and **indirect object**.

     Prepositions are also followed by objects.

121. **object complement**: a word that is used to describe the object of a clause and that occurs with verbs e.g. *make* and *find*; e.g. *It made me tired... I found her asleep.*

122. **ordinal number**: a number that is used to indicate where something comes in an order or sequence; e.g. *1st, 5th, 10th, 100th.*

123. **participle**: a verb form used for making different tenses.

     See ***-ed* participle** and ***-ing* participle** for more details.

124. **partitive**: a word that gives information about the amount of a particular thing; e.g. *pint, loaf, portion.*

125. **passive**: verb forms e.g. *was given, were taken, had been made*, where the subject is the person or thing that is affected by the action.

    Cf. **active**.

126. **past form**: the form of a verb, often ending in *-ed*, that is used for the past simple.

127. **past participle**: another name for ***-ed* participle**.

128. **past perfect**: the use of *had* with an *-ed* participle to refer to past events; e.g. *She had finished.*

129. **past perfect progressive**: the use of *had been* with an *-ing* participle to refer to past events; e.g. *He had been waiting for hours.*

    Also called **past perfect continuous**.

130. **past progressive**: the use of *was* or *were* with an *-ing* participle, usually to refer to past events; e.g. *They were worrying about it yesterday.*

    Also called **past continuous**.

131. **past simple**: the use of the past form of a verb to refer to past events; e.g. *They waited... It fell over.*

132. **past tense**: a tense used to describe actions or events that took place in the past.

    See **tense** for more details.

133. **perfect form**: a verb form with *have* and an *-ed* participle; e.g. *I have met him... We had won.*

134. **performative verb**: a verb that states explicitly what action the speaker is performing when he or she uses it; e.g. *apologize, resign, christen.*

135. **performer**: the person or thing that is responsible for the action expressed by the verb; e.g. *Mark phoned... Our dinner was eaten by the dog.*

136. **person**: a term used to refer to the 3 classes of people who are involved in something that is said.

    They are the 1st person (the person speaking or writing), the 2nd person (the person being addressed), and the 3rd person (the person or things that are being talked about).

137. **personal pronoun**: 1 of a group of pronouns including *I, you*, and *me* which are used to refer back to the people or things you are talking about.

138. **phrasal verb**: a combination of a verb and an adverb and/or a preposition, which have a single meaning; e.g. *back down, hand over, look after, look forward to.*

139. **phrase**: a set of words that is smaller than a clause, and that is based around a particular word class: e.g., a verb phrase is based around a main verb, and can also contain auxiliary verbs.

    See also **noun phrase, verb phrase** and **prepositional phrase**.

    Phrase is also sometimes used to refer to any group of words.

140. **plural**: the form used to refer to more than 1 person or thing; e.g. *dogs, women.*

141. **plural noun**: a noun that is only used in the plural form; e.g. *trousers, scissors, vermin.*

142. **possessive**: a structure used to show possession; e.g. *your, Jerry's, mine.*

143. **possessive determiner**: a determiner e.g. *my, your*, and *their.*

    Also called **possessive adjective**.

144. **possessive pronoun**: 1 of the words *mine, yours, hers, his, ours*, and *theirs.*

145. **postdeterminer**: a small group of adjectives used after a determiner and in front of other adjectives; e.g. *certain, remaining.*

146. **predeterminer**: a word that comes in front of a determiner; e.g. *all the boys... double the trouble... such a mess.*

147. **predicative**: used for describing the position of adjectives when they are used after a linking verb e.g. 'be'.

    Cf. **attributive**.

148. **preposition**: a word e.g. *by, with* or *from*, which is usually followed by a noun phrase or an *-ing* form.

149. **prepositional phrase**: a structure consisting of a preposition and its object; e.g. *on the table, by the sea.*

150. **present participle**: another name for ***-ing* participle**.

151. **present progressive**: the use of the present simple of 'be' with an *-ing* participle to refer to present events; e.g. *Things are improving.*

    Also called **present continuous**.

152. **present perfect**: the use of the present simple of *have* with an *-ed* participle to refer to past events that exist in the present; e.g. *She has loved him for 10 years.*

153. **present perfect progressive**: the use of *have been* and *has been* with an *-ing* participle to refer to past events that exist in the present; e.g. *We have been sitting here for hours.*

    Also called **present perfect continuous**.

154. **present simple**: the use of the base form or the *s* form of a verb, usually to refer to present events; e.g. *I like bananas... My sister hates them.*

155. **present tense**: a tense used to describe events taking place in the present, or situations that exist in the present.

156. **progressive**: a verb form that contains a form of the verb 'be' and an *-ing* participle; e.g. *She was laughing... They had been playing badminton.*

    Also called **continuous**.

157. **pronoun**: a word used instead of a noun, when you do not want to name someone or something directly; e.g. *it, you, none.*

158. **proper noun**: a noun that refers to a particular person, place, or institution; e.g. *Nigel, Edinburgh, Christmas.*

    Cf. **common noun**.

159. **purpose clause**: a subordinate clause, usually introduced by *in order to*, or *so that*;

    e.g. *I came here in order to ask you out to dinner.*

160. **qualifier**: any word, phrase, or clause that comes after a noun phrase, and gives extra information to expand its meaning; e.g. *... a book with a blue cover ... the shop on the corner.*

161. **qualitative adjective**: an adjective that is used to indicate a quality, and is gradable; e.g. *funny, intelligent, small.*

    Cf. **classifying adjective**.

162. **quantity expression**: a phrase ending in *of* that allows you to refer to a quantity of something without being precise about the exact amount; e.g. *some of, a lot of, a little bit of.*

163. **question**: a structure that typically has the verb in front of the subject and that is used to ask someone about something; e.g. *Have you have any money?*

    Also called **interrogative**.

164. **question tag**: a structure or word that is used at the end of a statement in order to form a question.

165. **reason clause**: a subordinate clause, usually introduced by *because, since*, or *as*; e.g. *Since you're here, we'll start.*

166. **reciprocal pronoun**: the pronouns *each other* and *one another*, used to show that 2 or more people do or feel the same thing; e.g. *They loved each other.*

167. **reciprocal verb**: a verb that describes an action that involves people affecting each other in the same way with the same action; e.g. *They met in the street... He met her yesterday.*

168. **reflexive pronoun**: a pronoun ending in *-self*, e.g. *myself* or *themselves*, which is used as the object of a verb when the person affected by an action is the same as the person doing it.

169. **reflexive verb**: a verb that is typically used with a reflexive pronoun; e.g. *enjoy yourself; pride yourself on.*

170. **reflexive clause**: a subordinate clause that gives more information about someone or something mentioned in the main clause.

    See also **defining relative clause** and **non-defining relative clause**.

171. **relative pronoun**: a *wh*-word e.g. *who* or *which*, used to introduce a relative clause; e.g. *... the girl who was carrying the bag.*

172. **reported clause**: the part of a reporting structure that describes what someone has said; e.g. *She said that I couldn't see her.*

173. **reported question**: a question that is reported using a reporting structure rather than the exact words used by the speaker.

174. **reported speech**: speech that is reported using a reporting structure rather than the exact words used by the speaker.

    Also called **indirect speech**.

175. **reporting clause**: a clause that contains a reporting verb, which is used to introduce what someone has said; e.g. *They asked if I could come.*

176. **reporting verb**: a verb that describes what people say or think; e.g. *suggest, say, wonder.*

177. **reporting structure**: a structure that reports what someone has said by using a reported clause rather than repeating their exact words; e.g. *She told me she'd be late.*

178. **result clause**: a subordinate clause introduced by *so that* which gives the result of something; e.g. *The house was severely damaged, so that it is now uninhabitable.*

179. **rhetorical question**: a question that you use in order to make a comment rather than to obtain information; e.g. *Oh, isn't it silly?*

180. **second person**: see **person**.

181. **semi-modal**: the verbs *dare, need*, and *used to* which behave rather like modals.

182. **sentence**: a group of words that express a statement, question, or command.

    A sentence usually has a verb and a subject, and may consist of 1 clause, or 2 or more clauses.

    A sentence in writing has a capital letter at the beginning and a full-stop, question mark, or exclamation mark at the end.

183. **sentence adverbial**: an adverbial that applies to the whole clause, rather than to part of it; e.g. *We possibly have to wait and see.*

    See also **sentence connector**.

184. **sentence connector**: a sentence adverbial used to introduce a comment or reinforce what is said; e.g. *moreover, besides.*

185. ***s* form**: the base form of a verb with *s* on the end, used in the present simple.

186. **simple sentence**: a sentence that contains only 1 clause.

187. **singular**: the form used to refer to or talk about 1 person or thing; e.g. *dog, woman.*

    Cf. **plural**.

188. **singular noun**: a noun typically used in the singular form; e.g. *sun, business.*

189. **split infinitive**: the placing of a word between *to* and the base form of a verb; e.g. *... to boldly go where no man has gone before.*

190. **split sentence**: a sentence in which emphasis is given to either the subject or the object by using a structure beginning with *it, what*, or *all*; e.g. *It's a hammer we need... What we need is a hammer.*

191. **stative verb**: a verb that describes a state ; e.g. *be, live, know.*

    Cf. **dynamic verb**.

192. **subject**: a noun phrase that usually comes before a verb, and agrees with the verb in person and number.

     In active sentences, the subject usually refers to the person or thing who dose the action expressed by the verb; e.g. *We were going shopping.*

193. **subjunctive**: a verb form that is used in some languages to express attitudes e.g. wishing, hoping, and doubting.

     The subjunctive is not very common in English, and is used mainly in conditional clauses e.g. *If I were you...*

194. **submodifying adverb**: an adverb that is used in front of an adjective or another adverb in order to strengthen or weaken its meaning; e.g. *... very interesting... quite quickly.*

195. **subordinate clause**: a clause that begins with a subordinating conjunction e.g. *because* or *while* and which must be used with a main clause.

196. **subordinating conjunction**: a conjunction that begins a subordinate clause.

197. **substitution**: the special use of pronouns and other words to replace part or all of a clause; e.g. *'Are you going to the party?' – 'I hope so'.*

198. **superlative**: an adjective or adverb with *-est* on the end or *most* in front of it; e.g. *thinnest, quickest, most wisely.*

199. **tense**: the verb form that shows whether you are referring to the past or the present.

200. ***that*-clause**: a clause starting with '*that*' which is used mainly when reporting what someone has said; e.g. *She said that she'd wash up for me.*

     That can be omitted when the clause is used after a reporting verb.

201. **third person**: see **person**.

202. **time adverbial**: an adverbial that gives more information about when something happens; e.g. *I saw her yesterday.*

203. **time clause**: a subordinate clause that indicates the time of an event; e.g. *I'll phone you when I get back.*

204. **title**: a word used before a person's name to show their position or status; e.g. *Mrs, Lord, Queen.*

205. ***to*-infinitive**: the base form of a verb preceded by *to*; e.g. *to go, to have, to jump.*

206. **transitive verb**: a verb used to talk about an action or event that involves more than 1 person or thing, and so is followed by an object; e.g. *She's wasting her money.*

207. **uncountable noun**: a noun that refers to a general kind of thing rather than to an individual item, and so has only 1 form; e.g. *money, furniture, intelligence.*

     Also called **uncount noun**.

208. **verb**: a word used with a subject to say what someone or something does, or what happens to them; e.g. *sing, spill, die.*

209. **verb phrase**: a main verb, or a main verb preceded by 1 or more auxiliary verbs, which combines with a subject to say what someone or something does, or what happens to them; e.g. *I'll show them... She's been sick.*

210. **vocative**: a word used when speaking to someone, just as if it were their name; e.g. *darling, madam.*

211. ***wh*-clause**: a clause starting with a *wh*-word.

212. ***whether*-clause**: a clause used to report a *yes/no*-question; e.g. *I asked her whether she'd seen him.*

213. ***wh*-question**: a question that expects an answer giving a particular person, place, thing, amount, and so on, rather than just *yes* or *no*.

214. ***wh*-word**: 1 of a group of words starting with *wh-*, e.g. *what, when* or *who*, which are used in *wh*-questions.

     How is also called a *wh*-word because it behaves like the other *wh*-words.

215. ***yes/no*-question**: a question that can be answered simply with either *yes* or *no*; e.g. *Would you like some more tea?*

Chapter 1

Referring to people & things: nouns, pronouns, & determiners

1.1 Introduction to the noun phrase

1.1 At its simplest, language is used to talk about people and things.

People do this by using words in a variety of ways, e.g. to make statements, to ask questions, and to give orders.

The words chosen are arranged into groups, either around a noun or around a verb.

They are called **noun phrases** and **verb phrases**.

Noun phrases tell us which people or things are being talked about.

Verb phrases tell us what is being said about them, e.g. what they are doing.

Chaps. 1–2 of this grammar deal with noun phrases.

For information about verb phrases, see Chap. 3.

1.2 A noun phrase can be the **subject** or **object** of a verb, it can follow a **linking verb**, or it can be the object of a **preposition**.

Example 1.1.1. *Babies cry when they are hungry.*

I couldn't feel anger against him.

They were teachers.

Let us work together in peace.

1.3 You use a noun phrase to talk about someone or something by naming them.

You do this by using a general name, called a **noun** or **common noun**, or by using a specific name, called a **proper noun**.

Proper nouns are mainly used for people, places, and events.

Example 1.1.2. *Mary likes strawberries.*

I went to Drexel University and then I went to Pittsburgh to work for a psychiatrist.

We flew to Genera with British Airways.

See paragraphs **1.52–1.58** for more information about **proper nouns**.

1.4 If you use a common noun, you are saying that the person or thing you are talking about can be put in a set with others that are similar in some way.

If you just want to say that the person or thing is in that set, you use an **indefinite determiner** with the common noun.

Example 1.1.3. *I met a girl who was a student there.*

Have you got any comment to make about that?

There are some diseases that are clearly inherited.

If you want to show which member of a set you are talking about, you use a **definite determiner** with a common noun.

Example 1.1.4. *I put my arm round her shoulders.*

... the destruction of their city.

She came in to see me this morning.

See paragraphs **1.162–1.251** for more information about **determiners**, and paragraphs **1.13–1.92** for more information about **nouns**.

1.5 You may decide not to name the person or thing and to use a **pronoun** rather than a proper noun or common noun.

You usually do this because the person or thing has already been named, so you refer to them by using a **personal pronoun** or a **demonstrative pronoun**.

Example 1.1.5. *Max will believe us, won't he?*
'Could I speak to Sue, please?' - 'I'm sorry, she doesn't work here now.'
Some people have servants to cook for them.
This led to widespread criticism.

See paragraphs **1.95–1.106** for more information about **personal pronouns**, and paragraphs **1.124–1.127** for more information about **demonstrative pronouns**.

1.6 You may decide not to name the person or thing at all, e.g. because you do not want to, you think it is not important, you do not know, or you want to be vague or mysterious while telling a story.

In such cases you use an **indefinite pronoun**, which does not refer to any particular person or thing.

Example 1.1.6. *I had to say something.*
In this country nobody trusts anyone.
A moment later, his heart seemed to stop as he sensed the sudden movement of someone behind him.

See paragraphs **1.128–1.141** for more information about **indefinite pronouns**.

1.7 If you want to give more information about the person or thing you are talking about, rather than just giving their general or specific name, you can use a **modifier** e.g. an **adjective**, or you can add extra information in the form of a phrase or a clause, for example.

1.8 Most **adjectives** are used as modifiers.

Nouns are also often used as modifiers.

Example 1.1.7. *... a big city.*
... blue ink.
He opened the car door.
... the oil industry.

See paragraphs **2.2–2.168** for more information about **adjectives**, and paragraphs **2.169–2.174** for more information about **noun modifiers**.

1.9 You can add a prepositional phrase, a relative clause, a relative clause, an adverb of place of time, or a *to*-infinitive after the noun.

Example 1.1.8. *... a girl in a dark grey dress.*
... the man who employed me.
... the room upstairs.
... the desire to kill.

Adjectives and participles are also sometimes used after the noun, usually in combination with other words.

Example 1.1.9. *... the Minister responsible for national security.*
... the 3 cards lying on the table.

See paragraphs **2.272–2.302** for more details about information that is added after the noun.

1.10 In particular, prepositional phrases beginning with *of* are very common, because they can express many different kinds of relationship between the 2 noun phrases.

Example 1.1.10. *... strong feelings of jealousy.*
... a picture of a house.
... the rebuilding of the old hospital.
... the daughter of the village cobbler.
... problems of varying complexity.
... the arrival of the police.

For more information about the use of *of* in the noun phrase see paragraphs **2.277–2.283**.

1.11 If you want to refer separately to more than 1 person or thing, or you want to describe them in more than 1 way, you link noun phrases using the **conjunctions** *and, or*, or *but*.

Sometimes you use a common instead of *and*, or just put 1 word next to another.

Example 1.1.11. ... *a table and chair.*
... *his obligations with regard to Amanda, Robert and Matthew.*
... *some fruit or cheese afterwards.*
... *her long black skirt.*

See paragraphs **8.171–8.201** for more information about the use of conjunctions to link noun phrases and words within noun phrases.

1.12 If you want to say how many things you are talking about, or how much of something here is, you use **numbers** and **quantity expressions**.

Example 1.1.12. *Last year I worked 7 days a week 14 hours a day.*
She drinks lots of coffee.

Numbers are dealt with in paragraphs **2.208–2.239**, and **quantity expressions** are dealt with in **2.175–2.193**.

1.2 Identifying people & things: nouns

1.13 A noun is used to identity a person or thing.

In this chapter 6 main types of noun are described.

They are classified according to whether they have a plural form, whether they need a determiner in front of them, and whether they occur with a singular verb or a plural verb when they are the subject of the verb.

The 6 types are:

classification: **example**: **comments**: **paragraph**

1. **countable nouns**: a bird, birds: have plural, need determiner: **1.15–1.22**
2. **uncountable nouns**: happiness equipment: no plural, usually no determiner: **1.23–1.33**
3. **singular nouns**: the moon, a day: no plural, need determiner: **1.34–1.40**
4. **plural nouns**: clothes scissors: no singular: **1.41–1.46**
5. **collective nouns**: the public, the staff: either singular or plural verb: **1.47–1.51**
6. **proper nouns**: Mary, London, The United Nations: start with capital letter: **1.52–1.58**

Many nouns have a number of different meanings, and so can be, e.g., a countable noun for 1 meaning, an uncountable noun for another, and a singular noun for another.

There are few other groups of nouns with special features.

These are dealt with in paragraphs **1.59–1.92**.

1.14 Most nouns do not begin with a capital letter, unless they are used to start a sentence.

However, the following types of noun are always spelled with a capital letter:

- **proper nouns** or names

  Example 1.2.1. ... *my sister Elizabeth.*

  I love reading Shakespeare.

  I'll be in the office on Monday.

  I think he's gone to London.

  For more information on proper nouns, see paragraphs **1.52–1.58**.

  Proper nouns that are time expressions are dealt with a Chap. 4, and those that are place names in Chap. 6.

- nouns that identify people of a particular nationality, or languages

  Example 1.2.2. *Can you think of some typical problems experienced by Germans learning English?*

- nouns that are the name of a particular product

  Example 1.2.3. *He drives a Porsche.*

  Put a bit of Sellotape across it.

1.2.1 Things that can be counted: countable nouns

1.15 Many nouns have 2 forms, the **singular** form, which is used to refer to 1 person or thing, and the **plural** form, which is used to refer to more than 1 person or thing.

These nouns refer to people or things that can be counted.

You can put numbers in front of them.

Example 1.2.4. ... *book*... *books*.
... *day*... *days*.
... *3 brothers*.
... *10 minutes*.

These nouns make up the largest group of nouns in English.

They are called **countable nouns**.

1.16 When you use the singular form of a countable noun as the subject of a verb, you use a singular verb.

When you use the plural form of a countable noun as the subject, you use a plural verb.

Example 1.2.5. *A dog likes to eat far more meat than a human being.*
Bigger dogs cost more.

1.17 Countable nouns have a determiner in front of them when they are used in the singular.

Example 1.2.6. *He got into the car and started the motor.*
They left the house to go for a walk after lunch.

When you use the plural form of a countable noun to talk about something in general, you do not use a determiner.

Example 1.2.7. *They all live in big houses.*
Most classrooms have computers.

However, if you are specifying a particular instance of something, you need to use a determiner.

Example 1.2.8. *The houses in our street are all identical.*
Our computers can give you all the relevant details.

1.18 Here is a list of some common countable nouns:

Example 1.2.9. *accident, account, actor, address, adult, animal, answer, apartment, article, artist, baby, bag, ball, bank, battle, beach, bed, bell, bill, bird, boat, book, bottle, box, boy, bridge, brother, bus, bush, camp, captain, car, card, case, castle, cat, chair, chapter, chest, child, cigarette, city, class, club, coat, college, computer, corner, country, crowd, cup, daughter, day, desk, doctor, dog, door, dream, dress, driver, ear, edge, effect, egg, election, engine, eye, face, factory, farm, father, field, film, finger, foot, friend, game, garden, gate, girl, group, gun, hall, hand, handle, hat, head, heart, hill, horse, hospital, hotel, hour, house, husband, idea, island, issue, job, journey, judge, key, king, kitchen, lady, lake, library, line, list, machine, magazine, man, meal, meeting, member, message, method, minute, mistake, model, month, motor, mouth, nation, neck, newspaper, office, page, park, party, path, picture, plan, plane, plant, problem, product, programme, project, ring, river, road, room, scheme, school, ship, shirt, shock, shop, sister, smile, son, spot, star, station, store, stream, street, student, table, task, teacher, tent, thought, tour, town, valley, village, walk, wall, week, window, woman, yard, year*

Note that many of these nouns have some meanings in which they are uncountable nouns, but they are countable nouns in their commonest meanings.

1.19 For most countable nouns the plural form has *-s* at the end, which distinguishes it from the singular form.

Example 1.2.10. ... *bed*... *beds*.
... *car*... *cars*.

Some countable nouns have other differences between the singular and plural forms.

Example 1.2.11. ... *bus*... *buses*.
... *lady*... *ladies*.
... *calf*... *calves*.
... *man*... *men*.
... *mouse*... *mice*.

For full information about the plural forms of countable nouns, see the Reference section.

1.20 Some countable nouns have the same form for both singular and plural.

Example 1.2.12. *... a sheep.*
... 9 sheep.

Many of these nouns refer to animals or fish; others are more varied in meaning:

Example 1.2.13. *bison, deer, elk, greenfly, grouse, moose, reindeer, sheep*
cod, fish, goldfish, halibut, mullet, salmon, shellfish, trout, whitebait
aircraft, hovercraft, spacecraft
crossroads, dice, fruit, gallows, grapefruit, insignia, mews, offspring, series, species
bourgeois, chassis, corps, patois, précis, rendezvous

1.21 The names of many animals and birds have 2 forms, one singular and one plural.
However, when you are referring to them in the context of hunting or when you are saying that there are large numbers of them, it is quite common to use the form without *-s*, even though you are referring to several animals or birds.

Example 1.2.14. *We went up north to hunt deer.*

Note that the plural form of the verb is used when several animals or birds are the subject of the sentence, even if you use the form without *-s*.

Example 1.2.15. *Zebra are a more difficult prey.*

Similarly, when you are referring to a large number of trees or plants growing together, you can use the singular form of their name.
When you are referring to a small number or to individual trees or plants, you usually use the form with *-s*.

Example 1.2.16. *Zebra are a more difficult prey.*

Similarly, when you are referring to a large number of trees or plants growing together, you can use the singular form of their name.
When you are referring to a small number or to individual trees or plants, you usually use the form with *-s*.

Example 1.2.17. *... the rows of willow and cypress which lined the creek.*
... the poplars and willows along the Peshawar Road.

1.22 [**Be creative**] Although some names of animals, birds, trees, and plants are commonly used in the singular form with plural meaning, in fact all such names can be used in this way.

1.2.2 Things not usually counted: uncountable nouns

1.23 Some nouns refer to general things e.g. qualities, substances, processes, and topics rather than to individual items or events.
These nouns have only 1 form, are not used with numbers, and are not usually used with the determiners *the, a*, or *an*.

Example 1.2.18. *... a boy or girl with intelligence.*
Make sure everyone has enough food and drink.
... new techniques in industry and agriculture.
I talked with people about religion, death, marriage, money, and happiness.

These nouns are called **uncountable nouns**.
1.24 When you use an uncountable noun as the subject of a verb, you use a singular form of the verb.

Example 1.2.19. *Love makes you do strange things.*
They believed that poverty was a threat to world peace.
Electricity is potentially dangerous.

1.25 Here is a list of some common uncountable nouns:

Example 1.2.20. *absence, access, age, agriculture, anger, atmosphere, beauty, behavior, cancer, capacity, childhood, china, comfort, concern, confidence, courage, death, democracy, depression, design, duty, earth, education, electricity, energy, environment, equipment, evil, existence, experience, failure, faith, fashion, fear, finance, fire, flesh, food, freedom, fun, ground, growth, happiness, health, help, history, ice, independence, industry, insurance, intelligence, joy, justice, labor, loneliness, love, luck, magic, marriage, mercy, music, nature, paper, patience, peace, philosophy, pleasure, policy, poverty, power, pride, protection, purity, rain, reality, refief, religion, respect, rice, safety, salt, sand, security, silence, sleep, strength, snow, spite, status, stuff, teaching, technology, time, trade, training, transport, travel, trust, truth, violence, waste, water, wealth, weather, welfare, wind, work, worth, youth*

[!] Be careful.

1.26 There are some words that are uncountable nouns in English, but that refer to things that are considered countable in other languages.

Here is a list of the most common uncountable nouns of this type:

Example 1.2.21. *advice, baggage, furniture, hair, homework, information, knowledge, luggage, machinery, money, news, progress, research, spaghetti, traffic*

1.27 Although uncountable nouns refer to things that cannot be counted and are not used with numbers, you often want to talk about an amount of something that is expressed by an uncountable noun.

Sometimes, you can do this by putting an **indefinite determiner** e.g. *all, enough, little*, or *some* in front of the noun.

Example 1.2.22. *Do you have enough money?*
There's some chocolate cake over there.

For more information on indefinite determiners that can be used with uncountable nouns, see paragraph **1.225**.

You can also put a **quantity expression** in front of the noun.

E.g., when you refer to water you can say *drops of water, a cup of water, 4 gallons of water*, and so on.

The use of quantity expressions with uncountable nouns is explained in paragraphs **2.194**–**2.207**.

1.28 When you are sure that your reader or hearer will understand that a quantity of something is being referred to, you do not need to use a quantity expression.

E.g., in a restaurant you can ask for *3 cups of coffee*, but you can also ask for *3 coffees* because the person you are talking to will know that you mean *3 cups of coffee*.

In this way, the uncountable noun *coffee* has become countable.

Nouns used in this way are called **mass nouns**.

1.29 Mass nouns are often used to refer to quantities of a particular kind of food or drink.

Example 1.2.23. *We spent 2 hours talking over coffee and biscuits in her study.*
We stopped for a coffee at a small café.

1.30 Similarly, some uncountable nouns can be mass nouns when they refer to types of something,

E.g., *cheese* is usually an uncountable noun but you can talk about *a large range of cheeses*.

Example 1.2.24. *... plentiful cheap beer.*
... profits from low-alcohol beers.
We were not allowed to buy wine or spirits at lunch time.
We shell a wide variety of wines and liqueurs.

Mass nouns referring to different types of a substance are mainly used in technical contexts.

E.g. *steel* is nearly always an uncountable noun, but in contexts where it is important to distinguish between different kinds of steel it can be a mass noun.

Example 1.2.25. *... imports of European steel.*
... the use of small amounts of nitrogen in making certain steels.

1.31 The following is a list of frequency used mass nouns:

Example 1.2.26. *adhesive, beer, brandy, bread, cake, cheese, claret, cloth, coal, coffee, cognac, coke, cotton, curry, deodorant, detergent, disinfectant, dye, fabric, fertilizer, fuel, fur, fin, glue, ink, insecticide, iron, jam, jelly, juice, lager, liqueur, lotion, material, meat, medicine, metal, milk, oil, ointment, ore, paint, perfume, pesticide, plastic, poison, preservative, ribbon, salad, sauce, sherry, soap, soil, soup, steel, sugar, tea, vodka, whisky, wine, wood, wool, yarn, yoghurt*

1.32 There are also some other nouns that can be uncountable nouns when they refer to a thing in general, and countable nouns when they refer to a particular instance of it.

Some nouns are commonly both uncountable nouns and countable nouns.

E.g., *victory* refers to the idea of winning in general but *a victory* refers to a particular occasion when someone wins.

Example 1.2.27. *He worked long and hard and finally led his team to victory.*
... his victory in the Australian Grand Prix.
Many parents were alarmed to find themselves in open conflict with the church.
Hundreds of people have died in ethnic conflicts.

Some uncountable nouns are rarely or never countable nouns; i.e., they do not occur in a plural form, or with a number.

Example 1.2.28. *... a collection of fine furniture.*
We found Alan weeping with relief and joy.
He saved money by refusing to have a telephone.

1.33 Some nouns that end in *-s* and look as if they are plural are in fact uncountable nouns.
This means that when they are the subject of a verb, the verb is in the singular.
These nouns refer mainly to subjects to study, activities, games, and diseases.

Example 1.2.29. *Physics is fun.*
Politics plays a large part in village life.
Economics is the oldest of the social sciences.
Darts is a very competitive sport.
Measles is in most cases a relatively harmless disease.

Here are 3 lists of uncountable nouns ending in *-s*.
These nouns refer to subjects of study and activities:

Example 1.2.30. *acoustics, aerobics, aerodynamics, aeronautics, athletics, classics, economics, electronics, genetics, gymnastics, linguistics, logistics, mathematics, mechanics, obstetrics, physics, politics, statistics, thermodynamics*

Note that some of these nouns are occasionally used as plural nouns, especially when you are talking about a particular person's work or activities.

Example 1.2.31. *His politics are clearly right-wing.*

These nouns refer to games:

Example 1.2.32. *billiards, bowls, cards, darts, draughts, skittles, tiddlywinks*

These nouns refer to diseases:

Example 1.2.33. *diabetes, measles, mumps, rabies, rickets, shingles*

1.2.3 When there is only 1 of something: singular nouns

1.34 There are certain things in the world that are unique.
There are other things that you almost always want to talk about one at a time.
This means that there are some nouns, or more often some meanings of nouns, for which only a singular form is used.
When a noun is used with such a meaning, it is called a **singular noun**.
Singular nouns are always used with a determiner, because they behave like the singular form of a countable noun.
1.35 When you use a singular noun as the subject of a verb, you use a singular form of the verb.

Example 1.2.34. *The sun was shining.*
The atmosphere is very relaxed.

1.36 Some singular nouns refer to 1 specific thing and therefore are used with the.
Some of these nouns, in fact, refer to something of which there is only one in the world.

Example 1.2.35. *There were huge cracks in the ground.*
The moon had not yet reached my window.
Burning tanks threw great spirals of smoke into the air.
He's always thinking about the the past and worrying about the future.

1.37 Other singular nouns can be used to refer to 1 thing only when it is obvious from the context what you are referring to.
E.g., if you are in Leeds and say *I work at the university*, you will almost certainly mean Leeds University.
However, in the following examples it is not clear exactly who or what the singular noun refers to, because there is not enough context.

Example 1.2.36. *In many countries the market is small numerically.*
Their company looks good only because the competition looks bad.
You've all missed the point.

Unless it is made clear which goods or products are being talked about, it is not possible for the reader or listener to be sure which group of potential buyers *the market* refers to.

Similarly it is not possible to know exactly which company or group of companies *the competition* refers to.

In the last example, the speaker is presumably going to state what he or she thinks *the point* is.

1.38 There are some activities that you do not usually do more than once at a time.

The nouns that refer to them are usually the object of a verb, and are used with the determiner *a*.

In this structure the verb has very little meaning and the noun carries most of the meaning of the whole structure.

For more information about these verb + object idioms, see paragraphs **3.32–3.45**.

Example 1.2.37. *I went and had a wash.*
Bruno gave it a try.

Some singular nouns are used so regularly with a particular verb that they have become fixed phrases and are idiomatic.

Example 1.2.38. *I'd like very much for you to have a voice in the decision.*
Isn't it time we made a move?

1.39 There are 2 special kinds of structure in which a singular noun is used.

A singular noun is sometimes used with the determiner *a* after a linking verb.

See paragraphs **3.126–3.181** for more information about **linking verbs**.

Example 1.2.39. *Decision-making is an art.*
The quickest way was by using the car.
It was a risk but he decided it had to be taken.
They were beginning to find Griffiths' visits rather a strain.

A singular noun is sometimes used with the determiner *the*, followed by a prepositional phrase beginning with *of*.

Example 1.2.40. *Comedy is the art of making people laugh.*
Old machines will be replaced by newer ones to reduce the risk of breakdown.
He collapsed under the strain of a heavy workload.

This group includes nouns used metaphorically; see paragraph **1.64** for more details.

Some singular nouns are always used to refer to 1 particular quality or thing, but are rarely used alone; i.e., they need to be specified in some way by the use of supporting material.

They can be used with a number of different determiners.

Example 1.2.41. *There was a note of satisfaction in his voice.*
Bessie covered the last 50 yards at a tremendous pace.
Simon allowed his pace to slacken.
She was simply incapable of behaving in a rational and considered manner.
... their manner of rearing their young.

Nouns that are rarely used alone without supporting material are discussed in detail in paragraphs **1.59–1.65**.

[i] Usage note.

1.40 Some nouns are used in the singular with a particular meaning only in an idiomatic phrase.

They have the appearance of singular nouns, but they are not used as freely as singular nouns.

Example 1.2.42. *What happens down there is none of my business.*
It's a pity I can't get to him.

1.2.4 Referring to more than 1 thing: plural nouns

1.41 There are some things that are considered to be plural rather than singular, so some nouns have only a plural form.

E.g., you buy *goods*, but not *a good*.

These nouns are called **plural nouns**.

Other nouns have only a plural form when they are used with a particular meaning.

E.g., an official meeting between American and Russian leaders is usually referred to as *talks* rather than as *a talk*.

In these meanings, these nouns are also called **plural nouns**.

Example 1.2.43. *Union leaders met the company for wage talks on Oct 9.*
It is inadvisable to sell goods on a sale or return basis.
Take care of your clothes.
The weather conditions were the same.
All proceeds are going to charity.
Employees can have meals on the premises.

Note that some plural nouns do not end in *-s*: e.g. *clergy, police, poultry*, and *vermin*.

1.42 When you use a plural noun as the subject of a verb, you use plural form of the verb.

Example 1.2.44. *Expenses for attending meetings are sometimes claimed.*
The foundations were shaking.
Refreshments were on sale in the café.
Attempts were made where resources were available.

1.43 You do not usually use numbers in front of plural nouns.

You can, however, use some **indefinite determiners** e.g. *some* or *many*.

For more information about the indefinite determiners that can be used with plural nouns, see the section beginning at paragraph **1.223**.

Some plural nouns usually have a definite determiner in front of them, because they are specific; some never have a determiner at all, because they are very general; and some are rarely used alone without extra information in the form of a phrase or a clause, e.g., because they need supporting material.

The lists in the following 2 paragraphs contain some common plural nouns that are frequently used in 1 of these ways.

Many of them have other meanings in which they are countable nouns.

1.44 Some plural nouns are most commonly used with *the*.

Example 1.2.45. *Things are much worse when the rains come.*
The authorities are concerned that the cocaine may be part of an international drug racket.
The coach tour of Gran Canaria was a wonderfully relaxing way to see the sights.

Here is a list of plural nouns that are most commonly used with *the*:

Example 1.2.46. *authorities, foundations, fruits, heavens, mains, odds, pictures, races, rains, sights, waters, wilds*

Some plural nouns are most commonly used with a possessive determiner e.g. *my* or *his*:

Example 1.2.47. *It offended her feelings.*
My travels up the Dalmation coast began in Dubrovnik.
This only added to his troubles.

Here is a list of plural nouns that are most commonly used with a possessive determiner:

Example 1.2.48. *activities, attentions, feelings, likes, movements, reactions, terms, travels, troubles, wants*

Some plural nouns are most commonly used without a determiner.

Example 1.2.49. *There were 1 or 2 cases where people returned goods.*
There is only 1 applicant, which simplifies matters.
They treated us like vermin.

Here is a list of plural nouns that are most commonly used without a determiner:

Example 1.2.50. *airs, appearances, events, expenses, figures, goods, matters, refreshments, riches, solids, talks, vermin*

Some plural nouns can be used both with or without determiners.

Example 1.2.51. *The house was raided by police.*
We call the police.
A luxury hotel was to be used as headquarters.
The city has been his headquarters for 5 years.
We didn't want it to dampen spirits which were required to remain positive.
The last few miles really lifted our spirits.

Here is a list of plural nouns that can be used with or without a determiner:

Example 1.2.52. *arms, basics, brains, clergy, costs, directions, essentials, greens, grounds, handcuffs, headquarters, interests, looks, means, morals, papers, particulars, people, police, poultry, premises, proceeds, rates, resources, specifics, spirits, supplies, talks, thanks, tracks, troops, values*

1.45 Some plural nouns are rarely used alone without a modifier, or some other form of extra information, because they need supporting material.

Example 1.2.53. *He doesn't tolerate bad manners.*
Our country's coastal defences need improving.
. . . the hidden pressures of direct government funding.

Here is a list of plural nouns that are rarely used alone without a modifier or some other extra information:

Example 1.2.54. *affairs, conditions, defences, demands, details, effects, forces, hopes, lines, manners, materials, matters, pressures, proportions, quarters, relations, remains, sands, services, thoughts, wastes, ways, words, works, writings*

1.46 2 special groups of nouns are usually plural: nouns referring to clothes and some other things that people wear, and nouns referring to tools and some other things that people use.
This is because some clothes and tools, e.g. *trousers* and *scissors*, are made up of 2 similar parts.

Example 1.2.55. *She wore brown trousers and a green sweater.*
He took off his glasses.
. . . using the pliers from the toolbox.

When you want to refer to these items in general, or to an unspecified number of them, you use the plural form with no determiner.

Example 1.2.56. *Never poke scissors into a light bulb socket.*
The man was watching the train through binoculars.

Here is a list of some plural nouns that refer to clothes and other things that people wear:

Example 1.2.57. *braces, briefs, cords, dungarees, glasses, jeans, jodhpurs, knickers, leggings, overalls, panties, pants, pyjamas, shorts, slacks, specs, spectacles, sunglasses, tights, trousers, trunks, underpants*

Here is a list of plural nouns that refer to tools and other things that people use:

Example 1.2.58. *binoculars, clippers, compasses, dividers, nutcrackers, pincers, pliers, scales, scissors, secateurs, shears, tongs, tweezers*

When you want to refer to a single piece of clothing or a single tool, you use *some* or *a pair of* in front of the noun.
You refer to more than 1 item by using a number or a quantity expression with *pairs of*.

Example 1.2.59. *I got some scissors out of the kitchen drawer.*
I went out to buy a pair of scissors.
He was wearing a pair of old grey trousers.
Liza has 3 pairs of jeans.

You can also use *a pair of* when you are talking about things e.g. gloves, shoes, and socks that typically occur in twos.

Example 1.2.60. *. . . a pair of new gloves.*

A possessive determiner e.g. *my* can be used instead of *a*.

Example 1.2.61. *. . . his favorite pair of shoes.*

When you use *a pair of* with a noun in the plural form, the verb is singular if it is in the same clause.
If the verb is in a following relative clause, it is usually plural.

Example 1.2.62. *It is likely that a new pair of shoes brings more happiness to a child than a new car brings to a grown-up.*
I always wear a pair of long pants underneath, or a pair of pyjamas is just as good.
He put on a pair of brown shoes, which were waiting there for him.
He wore a pair of earphones, which were plugged into a radio.

You use a plural pronoun after *a pair of*.

Example 1.2.63. *She went to the wardrobe, chose a pair of shoes, put them on and leaned back in the chair.*
He brought out a pair of dark glasses and handed them to Walker.

1.2.5 Referring to groups: collective nouns

1.47 Some nouns in English refer to a group of people or things.

These nouns are called **collective nouns**.

They have only 1 form, but many collective nouns have other meanings in which they are countable nouns with 2 forms.

1.48 When you use a collective noun, you can use either a singular verb or a plural verb after it.

You choose a singular verb if you think of the group as a single unit, and a plural verb if you think of the group as a number of individuals.

Example 1.2.64. *Our little group is complete again.*
A 2nd group are those parents who feel that we were too harsh.
Our family isn't poor any more.
My family are all perfectly normal.
The enemy was moving slowly to the east.
The enemy were visibly cracking.
His arguments were confined to books which the public was unlikely to read.
The public were deceived by the newspapers.

[**AE**] In American English, it is more usual to use a singular verb unless the sentence contains an element that clearly refers to more than 1 person or thing.

The names of many organizations are collective nouns, and can be used with a singular or a plural verb.

Example 1.2.65. *The BBC is sending him to Tuscany for the summer.*
The BBC are planning to use the new satellite next month.
England was leading 18-0 at half-time.
England are seeking alternatives for their B team.

[**AE**] American English uses a singular verb for these.

Example 1.2.66. *GE reports its 2nd-quarter financial results on Jul 16.*
New England is going to sign him to a long-term contract.

If you want to refer back to a collective noun, you choose a singular pronoun or determiner if the previous verb is singular, and a plural pronoun or determiner if the previous verb is plural.

Example 1.2.67. *The government has said it would wish to do this only if there was no alternative.*
The government have made up their minds that they're going to win.

[**i**] **Usage note.**

1.49 Note that the words *bacteria, data*, and *media* are now often used as collective nouns, that is with either a singular or a plural verb and no change in form.

Some careful speakers think they should only be used with a plural verb because they have the rare singular forms *bacterium, datum*, and *medium* and are therefore countable nouns.

Example 1.2.68. *Medieval Arabic data show that the length of the day has been increasing more slowly than expected.*
Our latest data shows more firms are hoping to expand in the near future.

[**!**] **Be careful.**

1.50 Although you can use a plural verb after a collective noun, these nouns do not behave like the plural forms of countable nouns.

E.g., you cannot use numbers in front of them.

You cannot say *3 enemy were killed.*

You have to say *3 of the enemy were killed.*

1.51 Here is a list of common collective nouns:

Example 1.2.69. *aristocracy, army, audience, bacteria, brood, cast, committee, community, company, council, crew, data, enemy, family, flock, gang, government, group, herd, jury, media, navy, nobility, opposition, panel, press, proletariat, public, staff, team*

Some collective nouns are also **partitives** (nouns that are used to talk about a quantity of something).

E.g., you talk about *a flock of sheep* and *a herd of cattle.*

See paragraph **2.198** for more information about these.

1.2.6 Referring to people & things by name: proper nouns

1.52 When you talk about a particular person, you can use their name.
Names are usually called **proper nouns**.
People's names are spelled with a capital letter, and do not have a determiner in front of them.

Example 1.2.70. ... *Michael Hall... Jenny... Smith.*

Ways of using people's names when you are speaking to them directly are explained in paragraph **9.95–9.99**.

1.53 Sometimes a person's name is used to refer to something they create.
You can refer to a painting, sculpture, or book by a particular person by using the person's name like a countable noun.
You still spell it with a capital letter.

Example 1.2.71. *In those days you could buy a Picasso for £300.*
I was looking at their Monets and Matisses.
I'm reading an an Agatha Christie at the moment.

You can refer to music composed or performed by a particular person by using the person's name like an uncountable noun.

Example 1.2.72. *I remembered it when we were listening to the Mozart.*
... instead of playing Chopin and Stravinsky all the time.

1.54 Nouns that refer to relationships between the people in a family, e.g. *mother, dad, aunt*, and *grandpa*, can also be used like names to address people or refer to them.
They are then spelled with a capital letter.

Example 1.2.73. *I'm sure Mum will be pleased.*

1.55 Words that show someone's social status or job are called **titles**.
They are spelled with a capital letter.
You use a title in front of a person's name, usually their surname or their full name, when you are talking about them in a fairly formal way or are showing respect to them.

Example 1.2.74. ... *Doctor Barker... Lord Curzon... Captain Jack Langtry... Mrs Ford.*

Here is a list of the most common titles that are used before names:

Example 1.2.75. *Admiral, Archbishop, Baron, Baroness, Bishop, Brother, Captain, Cardinal, Colonel, Congressman, Constable, Corporal, Dame, Doctor, Emperor, Father, General, Governor, Imam, Inspector, Justice, King, Lady, Lieutenant, Lord, Major, Miss, Mr, Mrs, Ms, Nurse, Police Constable, Pope, President, Prince, Princess, Private, Professor, Queen, Rabbi, Representative, Saint, Senator, Sergeant, Sir, Sister*

A few titles, e.g. *King, Queen, Prince, Princess, Sir*, and *Lady*, can be followed just by the person's 1st name.

Example 1.2.76. ... *Queen Elizabeth.*
... Prince Charles' eldest son.
Sir Michael has made it very clear indeed.

Ways of using titles when you are speaking to people directly are explained in paragraphs **9.97–9.98**.

1.56 Determiners, other modifiers, and phrases with *of* are sometimes used with titles, and the person's name is omitted.

Example 1.2.77. ... *Her Majesty the Queen and the Duke of Edinburgh.*
... the Archbishop of Canterbury.
... the President of the United States.
... the Bishop of Birmingham.

1.57 Most words that are titles can also be countable nouns, usually without a capital letter.

Example 1.2.78. ... *lawyers, scholars, poets, presidents and so on.*
... a foreign prince.
Maybe he'll be a Prime Minister 1 day.

1.58 The names of organizations, institutions, ships, magazines, books, plays, paintings, and other unique things are also proper nouns and are spelled with capital letters.

Example 1.2.79. ... *British Broadcasting Corporation*
... *Birmingham University.*

They are sometimes used with *the* or another determiner.

Example 1.2.80. ... *the United Nations* ... *the Labor Party*... *the University of Birmingham*... *the Queen Mary*... *the Guardian*... *the Wall Street Journal*... *the British Broadcasting Corporation.*

The determiner is not spelled with a capital letter, except in the names of books, plays, and paintings.

Example 1.2.81. ... *The Grapes of Wrath.*
... *A Midsummer Night's Dream.*

Some time expressions are proper nouns, and are dealt with in Chap. 4.

1.2.7 Nouns that are rarely used alone

1.59 There are some nouns that are rarely used alone.

They need extra material e.g. an adjective or a following phrase, because the meaning of the noun would not be clear without it.

Some of these nouns have many meanings; others have very little meaning on their own.

E.g., you cannot usually refer to someone as *the head* without saying which organization they are head of.

Similarly, you cannot say that there was *a note* in someone's voice without describing it as, e.g., *a triumphant note* or *a note of triumph.*

These nouns are used on their own only if it is obvious from the context what is meant.

E.g., if you have just mentioned a mountain and you say *the top*, it is clear that you mean the top of that mountain.

1.60 A **modifier** is an adjective or a noun that is added to a noun in order to give more information about it.

Example 1.2.82. ... *her wide experience of political affairs.*
I detected an apologetic note in the agent's voice.
He did not have British citizenship.
Check the water level.

For more information on modifiers, see Chap. 2.

1.61 Extra information after the noun is usually in the form of a phrase beginning with *of.*

Example 1.2.83. ... *at the top of the hill.*
There he saw for himself the extent of the danger.
Ever since the rise of industrialism, education has concentrated on producing workers.
... *a high level of interest.*

For more information, see paragraphs **2.272**–**2.302**.

1.62 Some nouns are always used with a modifier.

E.g., you would not say that someone is *an eater* because all people eat, but you may want to say that he or she is *a meat eater* or *a messy eater.*

Similarly, if you use *range*, you have to refer to a particular *price range* or *age range.*

If you use *wear* to mean *clothing*, you have to say what sort of clothing, e.g. *sports wear* or *evening wear.*

Example 1.2.84. *Time was a slow eater.*
... *the other end of the age range.*
The company has plans to expand its casual wear.

1.63 Some nouns are almost always used with a possessive, that is a **possessive determiner**, **'s**, or a prepositional phrase beginning with *of*, because you have to show who or what the thing you are talking about relates to or belongs to.

Example 1.2.85. *The company has grown rapidly since its formation 10 years ago.*
Advance warning of the approach of enemies was of the greatest importance.
... *the portrait of a man in his prime.*

1.64 Nouns that are being used metaphorically (= when 1 thing is used to describe another thing) often have a modifier or some other form of extra information, often in the form of a phrase beginning with *of*, to show what is really being referred to.

Example 1.2.86. ... *the maze of politics.*
He has been prepared to sacrifice this company on the altar of his own political ambitions.
He has worked out a scheme for an economic lifeline by purchasing land.
Lloyd's of London is the heart of the world's insurance industry.
... those on the lower rungs of the professional ladder.

1.65 Many nouns have some meanings that need a modifier or some other form of extra information, and other meanings that do not.

Here is a list of these nouns:

Example 1.2.87. *affair, approach, area, back, band, base, bottom, boundary, branch, case, center, circumstances, citizenship, class, condition, crisis, culture, depth, development, discovery, eater, edge, edition, element, end, enterprise, epidemic, experience, extent, feeling, field, formation, fringe, ground, growth, head, height, impression, inception, kind, length, level, limit, line, matter, movement, nature, note, period, point, position, power, prime, range, rate, regime, relic, repertoire, rise, role, scale, side, sort, stage, status, structure, stuff, style, system, texture, theory, thought, time, tone, top, transfer, type, version, view, wave, way, wear, wing, world*

1.2.8 Adjectives used as nouns: *the poor, the impossible*

1.66 When you want to talk about groups of people who share the same characteristic or equality, you can use *the* + adjective.

E.g., instead of saying *poor people*, you can say *the poor.*

Example 1.2.88. ... *the help that's given to the blind.*
No effort is made to cater for the needs of the elderly.
... the task of rescuing the injured.
... men and women who would join the sad ranks of the unemployed.
Working with the young is stimulating and full of surprises.
... providing care for the sick, the aged, the workless and the poor.

Note that you never add *-s* to the adjective, even though it always refers to more than 1 person.

[⋆] **Be creative.**

1.67 Although some adjectives are commonly used in this way, in fact it is possible to use almost any adjective in this way.

1.68 When the adjective being used as a noun is the subject of a verb, you use a plural form of the verb.

Example 1.2.89. *The rich have benefited much more than the poor.*

1.69 If you want to talk about a more specific group of people, you put a **submodifying adverb** (= an adverb that you put in front of an adjective to give more information about it) or another adjective in front of the headword.

For more information about submodifying adverbs, see paragraphs **2.140–2.168**.

Example 1.2.90. *In this anecdote, Ray shows his affection for the very old and the very young.*
... the highly educated.
... the urban poor.

If you mention 2 groups, you sometimes omit *the.*

Example 1.2.91. ... *a study that compared the diets of rich and poor in several nations.*
... to help break down the barriers between young and old.

With a few words e.g. *unemployed* and *dead*, you can say how many people you are referring to by putting a number in front of them.

Example 1.2.92. *We estimate there are about 300 dead.*

1.70 When you want to refer to the quality of something rather than to the thing itself, you can use the appropriate adjective with *the.*

Example 1.2.93. *Don't you think that you're wanting the impossible?*
He is still exploring the limits of the possible.
... a mix of the traditional and the modern.

1.71 All color adjectives can also be used as nouns.

Example 1.2.94. *... patches of blue.*
... brilliant paintings in reds and greens and blues.

Clothing of a particular color can be referred to simply by using the color adjective.

Example 1.2.95. *The men wore grey.*
... the fat lady in black.

[i] Usage note.
1.72 Nationality adjectives that end in *-ch, -sh, -se*, or *-ss* can be used in a similar way, unless there is a separate noun for the people.
E.g., French people are referred to as *the French* but Polish people are referred to as *Poles* or *the Poles*.

Example 1.2.96. *For many years the Japanese have dominated the market for Chinese porcelain.*
Britons are the biggest consumers of chocolate after the Swiss and the Irish.

1.2.9 Nouns referring to males or females

1.73 English nouns are not masculine, feminine, or neuter in the way that nouns in some other languages are.
E.g., most names of jobs, e.g. *teacher, doctor*, and *writer*, are used for both men and women.
But some nouns refer only to males and others only to females.
E.g., some nouns indicating people's family relationships, e.g. *father, brother*, and *son*, and some nouns indicating people's jobs, e.g. *waiter* and *policeman*, are used only to refer to males.
In the same way *mother, sister, daughter, waitress, actress*, and *sportswoman* are used only to refer to females.
1.74 Words that refer to women often end in *-ess*, e.g. *actress, waitress*, and *hostress*.
Another ending is *-woman*, as in *policewoman* and *sportswoman*.

Example 1.2.97. *... his wife Susannah, a former air stewardess.*
A policewoman dragged me out of the crowd.
Steph Burton was named sportswoman of the year.

1.75 Words ending in *-man* are either used to refer only to men or to both men and women.
E.g., a *postman* is a man, but a *spokesman* can be a man or a woman.
Some people now use words ending in *-person*, e.g. *chairperson* and *spokesperson*, instead of words ending in *-man*, in order to avoid appearing to refer specifically to a man.
[i] Usage note.
1.76 Most names of animals are used to refer to both male and female animals, e.g. *cat, elephant, horse, monkey*, and *sheep*.
In some cases there are different words that refer specifically to male animals or female animals, e.g. a male horse is a *stallion* and a female horse is a *mare*.
In other cases the general name for the animal is also the specific word for males or females: *dog* also refers more specifically to male dogs, *duck* also refers more specifically to female ducks.
Many of these specific words are rarely used, or used mainly by people who have a special interest in animals, e.g. farmers or vets.
Here is a list of some common specific words for male and female animals:

Example 1.2.98. *stallion, mare*
bull, cow
cock, hen
dog, bitch
drake, duck
fox, vixen
gander, goose
lion, lioness
ram, ewe
buck, hind, stag, doe
tiger, tigress
boar, sow

1.2.10 Referring to activities & processes: *-ing* nouns

1.77 When you want to talk about an action, activity, or process in a general way, you can use a noun that has the same form as the *-ing* participle of a verb.

These nouns are called different things in different grammars: gerunds, verbal nouns, or *-ing* forms.

In this grammar they are referred to as ***-ing* nouns**.

It is sometimes difficult to distinguish and ***-ing* noun** from an ***-ing* participle**, and it is usually not necessary to do so.

However, there are times when it is clearly a noun, e.g. when it is the subject of a verb, the object of a verb, or the object of a preposition.

Example 1.2.99. *Swimming is a great sport.*
The emphasis was on teaching rather than learning.
The closing of so many mills left thousands unemployed.
Some people have never done any public speaking.

The spelling of *-ing* nouns is explained in the Reference section.

The use of *-ing* adjectives is explained in paragraphs **2.63**–**2.76**.

1.78 Because *-ing* nouns refer to activities in a general way, they are usually **uncountable nouns**; i.e., they have only 1 form, cannot be used with numbers, and do not usually have a determiner in front of them.

For more information on uncountable nouns, see paragraphs **1.23**–**1.33**.

1.79 You often use an *-ing* noun because it is the only noun form available for certain verbs, e.g. *eat, hear, go, come*, and *bless*.

Other verbs have related nouns that are not *-ing* nouns: e.g. *see* and *sight*; *arrive* and *arrival*, *depart* and *departure*.

Example 1.2.100. *Eating is an important part of a cruise holiday.*
. . . loss of hearing in 1 ear.
Only 6% of children receive any further training when they leave school.

1.80 If you want to describe the action expressed by the noun, you use 1 or more adjectives or nouns in front of it.

Example 1.2.101. *He served a jail sentence for reckless driving.*
The police need better training in dealing with the mentally ill.
He called for a national campaign against under-age drinking.

1.81 A few *-ing* nouns, mostly words for sporting or leisure activities, and much more common than their related verbs.

In some cases there is no verb, although it is always possible to invent one.

E.g., you are more likely to say *We want caravanning around France* than *We caravanned around France*.

Here is a list of the commonest of these nouns:

Example 1.2.102. *angling, boating, bowling, canoeing, caravanning, electioneering, hang-gliding, mountaineering, paragliding, shoplifting, shopping, sightseeing, skateboarding, snorkeling, snowboarding, surfing, weightlifting, window-shopping, windsurfing, yachting*

Although these words are not always associated with a verb, most of them can be used as *-ing* participles.

Example 1.2.103. *I spent the afternoon window-shopping with Grandma.*

1.82 Some *-ing* nouns that are related to verbs are **countable nouns**.

They generally refer to the result of an action or process, or to an individual instance of it.

Sometimes their meaning is not closely related to that of the verb.

Here is a list of the commonest of these nouns:

Example 1.2.104. *beginning, being, building, drawing, feeling, finding, hearing, meaning, meeting, offering, painting, saying, setting, showing, sitting, suffering, turning, warning*

For more information on countable nouns, see paragraphs **1.15**–**1.22**.

1.2.11 Compound nouns: *car park, mother-in-law, breakdown*

1.83 A single noun is often not enough to refer clearly to a person or thing.

When this is the case, a **compound noun** can be used.

A compound noun is a fixed expression that is made from more than 1 word, and that behaves as a noun.

Example 1.2.105. *Some people write out a new address book every January.*
How would one actually choose a small personal computer?
Where did you hide the can opener?
... a private swimming pool.

Once it is clear what you are referring to, it is sometimes possible to use just the 2nd word of a 2-word compound noun. E.g., after mentioning *a swimming pool*, you can just refer to *the pool*.
Most compound nouns consist of 2 words, but some consist of 3 or more words.

Example 1.2.106. *... a vase of lily of the valley.*

1.84 Some compound nouns are written with hyphens instead of spaces between the words.

Example 1.2.107. *I'm looking forward to a lie-in tomorrow.*
He's very good at problem-solving.
Judy's brother-in-law lived with his family.

Some compound nouns, especially very frequent ones, are written as 1 word.

Example 1.2.108. *... patterned wallpaper.*
They copied questions from the blackboard.

In some cases, you can choose whether to write a compound noun with or without a hyphen, or with or without a space. E.g., both *air-conditioner* and *air conditioner* are possible, and both *postbox* and *post box* are possible.
A few compound nouns that consist of more than 2 words are written partly with hyphens and partly with spaces, e.g. *back-seat driver* and *bring-and-buy sale*.

Example 1.2.109. *... children from 1-parent families.*
... a Parent-Teacher Association.

1.85 Compound nouns may be countable, uncountable, singular, or plural.
Here is a list of some common countable compound nouns:

Example 1.2.110. *address book, air conditioner, air raid, alarm clock, assembly line, baby-sitter, back-seat driver, bank account, bird of prey, book token, blood donor, bride-to-be, bring-and-buy sale, brother-in-law, burglar alarm, bus stop, can opener, car park, compact disc, contact lens, credit card, dining room, drawing pin, driving license, estate agent, fairytale, father-in-law, film star, fire engine, fork-lift truck, frying pan, guided missile, health center, heart attack, high school, human being, letter box, lily of the valley, mother-in-law, musical instrument, nervous breakdown, news bulletin, old hand, 1-parent family, package holiday, Parent-Teacher, Association, parking meter, pen-friend, personal computer, polar bear, police station, post office, rolling pin, sister-in-law, sleeping bag, swimming pool, T-shirt, tea bag, telephone number, traveler's cheque, washing machine, X-ray, youth hostel, zebra crossing.*

1.86 Here is a list of some common uncountable compound nouns:

Example 1.2.111. *air conditioning, air-traffic control, barbed wire, birth control, blood pressure, bubble bath, capital punishment, central heating, chewing gum, common sense, cotton wool, data processing, do-it-yourself, dry-cleaning, family planning, fancy dress, fast food, 1st aid, food poisoning, further education, general knowledge, hay fever, heart failure, higher education, hire purchase, income tax, junk food, law and order, lost property, mail order, mineral water, nail varnish, natural history, old age, pocket money, remote control, science fiction, show business, show jumping, sign language, social security, social work, soda water, stainless steel, table tennis, talcum powder, toilet paper, tracing paper, unemployment benefit, value added tax, washing powder, washing-up liquid, water-skiing, writing paper*

1.87 Here is a list of some common singular compound nouns:

Example 1.2.112. *age of consent, arms race, brain drain, continental divide, cost of living, death penalty, diplomatic corps, dress circle, fire brigade, general public, generation gap, greenhouse effect, hard core, human race, labor force, labor market, long jump, mother tongue, open air, private sector, public sector, rank and file, solar system, sound barrier, space age, welfare state, women's movement*

1.88 Here is a list of some common plural compound nouns:

Example 1.2.113. *armed forces, baked beans, civil rights, current affairs, French fries, grass roots, high heels, human rights, industrial relations, inverted commas, licensing laws, luxury goods, modern languages, natural resources, race relations, road works, social services, social studies, swimming trunks, vocal cords, winter sports, yellow pages*

1.89 Most compound nouns consist of 2 nouns, or an adjective and a noun.

Example 1.2.114. *I listened with anticipation to the radio news bulletin.*
. . . a big dining room.
Old age is a time for reflection and slowing down.

however, some compound nouns are related to **phrasal verbs**.
These are sometimes written with a hyphen, and sometimes as 1 word.
They are rarely written as separate words.

Example 1.2.115. *The President was directly involved in the Watergate cover-up.*
I think there's been a mix-up.
. . . a breakdown of diplomatic relations.
The singer is making a comeback.

Here is a list of frequent nouns based on phrasal verbs.
They are shown in this list in the form in which they are most frequently written, either with a hyphen or as 1 word.

Example 1.2.116. *backup, bailout, blackout, breakaway, breakdown, break-in, breakout, break-up, build-up, buyout, check-in, checkout, check-up, comeback, cover-up, crackdown, cutbacks, drawback, feedback, follow-up, giveaway, handout, kick-off, lead-up, lookout, make-up, meltdown, mix-up, passer-by, run-in, runner-up, run-off, run-up, sell-out, setback, set-up, show-off, slowdown, takeaway, take-off, turnover, warm-up*

For more information about phrasal verbs, see paragraphs **3.83–3.116**.
[i] Usage note.
1.90 In some cases, the meaning of a compound noun is not obvious from the words it consists of.
E.g., someone's *mother tongue* is not the tongue of their mother but the language they learn as a child, and an *old hand* is not a hand that is old but a person who is experienced at doing a particular job.
[Bubble] In other cases, the compound noun consists of words that do not occur on their own, e.g. *hanky-panky, hodge-podge*, and *argy-bargy.*
These nouns are usually used in informal conversation rather than formal writing.

Example 1.2.117. *Most of what he said was a load of hocus-pocus.*
She is usually involved in some sort of jiggery-pokery.

1.91 The plural forms of compound nouns vary according to the type of words that they consist of.
If the final word of a compound noun is a countable noun, the plural form of the countable noun is used when the compound noun is plural.

Example 1.2.118. *Air raids were taking place every night.*
. . . health centers, banks, post offices, and police stations.
Loud voices could be heard through letter boxes.
. . . the refusal of dockers to use fork-lift trucks.

For full information about the plural forms of countable nouns, see the Reference section.
Compound nouns that are directly related to phrasal verbs usually have a plural form ending in *-s*.

Example 1.2.119. *Nobody seems disturbed about cover-ups when they are essential to the conduct of a war.*
Naturally, I think people who drive smarter, faster cars than mine are show-offs.

A few compound nouns are less directly related to phrasal verbs, and consist of a countable noun and an adverb.
In these cases, the plural form of the countable noun is used before the adverb when the compound noun is plural.
E.g., the plural of *runner-up* is *runners-up*, and the plural of *summing-up* is *summings-up*.

Example 1.2.120. *Passers-by helped the victim, who was unconscious.*

Compound nouns that consist of 2 nouns linked by the prepositions *of* or *in*, or a noun followed by *to-be*, have a plural form in which the 1st noun in the compound is plural.

Example 1.2.121. *I like birds of prey and hawks particularly.*
She was treated with contempt by her sisters-in-law.
Most mothers-to-be in their 40s opt for this test.

Some compound nouns have been borrowed from other languages, mainly French and Latin, and therefore do not have normal English plural forms.

Example 1.2.122. *Agents provocateurs were sent to cause trouble.*
The nouveaux riches of younger states are building palatial mansions for themselves.

1.92 Compound nouns are fixed expressions.
However, nouns can always be used in front of other nouns in order to refer to something in a more specific way.
For the use of nouns as **modifiers**, see paragraphs **2.169–2.174**.

1.3 Talking about people & things without naming them: pronouns

1.93 When you use language, both in speech and writing, you constantly refer to things you have already mentioned or are about to mention.
You can do this by repeating the noun phrase, but unless there is a special reason to do so, you are more likely to use a **pronoun** instead.
Pronouns make statements less repetitive.

Example 1.3.1. *John took the book and opened it.*
Deborah recognized the knife as hers.
Shilton was pleased with himself.
This is a very busy place.

However, if you have mentioned 2 or more different things, you usually have to repeat the noun phrase to make it clear which thing you are now talking about.

Example 1.3.2. *Leaflets and scraps of papers were scattered all over the floor.*
I started to pick up the leaflets.
I could see a lorry and a car.
The lorry stopped.

For other ways of talking about things that have already been mentioned, see paragraphs **10.2–10.39**.
1.94 There are several different types of pronoun:

- **personal pronouns**. See paragraphs **1.95–1.106**.
- **possessive pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.107–1.110**.
- **reflexive pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.111–1.118**.
- **generic pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.119–1.123**.
- **demonstrative pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.124–1.127**.
- **indefinite pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.128–1.141**.
- **reciprocal pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.142–1.145**.
- **relative pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.146–1.150**.
- **interrogative pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.151–1.153**.

There are a few other words that can be used as pronouns.
For more information about these, see paragraphs **1.154–1.161**.

1.3.1 Talking about people & things: personal pronouns

1.95 You use **personal pronouns** to refer to yourself, the people you are talking to, or the people or things you are talking about.
There are 2 sets of personal pronouns: subject pronouns and object pronouns.
1.96 Subject pronouns refer to the subject of a clause.
Here is a table of subject pronouns:

	singular	**plural**
1st person	I	we
2nd person	you	you
3rd person	he, she, it	they

1.97 You refer to yourself by using the pronoun *I*.
I is always written with a capital letter.

Example 1.3.3. *I don't know what to do.*
I think I made the wrong decision.
May I ask why Stephen's here?

1.98 You refer to the person or people you are talking to as *you*.
Note that the same word is used for the singular and the plural.

Example 1.3.4. *You may have to wait a bit.*
Would you come and have a drink?
How did you get on?

You is also used to refer to people in general, rather than to the person you are talking or writing to.
For more information on this, see paragraph **1.120**.
If you want to make it clear that you are addressing more than 1 person, you can create a plural form by using *you* followed by a determiner, a number or a noun.
Forms like this can also be used in object position.

Example 1.3.5. *My granddad wants you both to come round next Saturday.*
As you all know, this is a challenge.

Here is a list of the most common plural forms of *you*.

Example 1.3.6. *you all, you guys, you lot, you 2, you 3, you both*

You guys and *you lot* are more frequent in informal English.
You lot is not commonly used in American English.

Example 1.3.7. *I love working with you guys.*
You guys are great!
So you lot will have to look after yourselves.

Note that people often use *you lot* when they are being very direct with a group of people, as in the last example above.
[AE] Some varieties and dialects of English have developed particular forms of plural *you*.
In American English, particularly Southern American English, *y'all* is sometimes used, especially in speech.

Example 1.3.8. *What did y'all eat for breakfast?*
I want to thank y'all.

In some dialects of British and American English, *yous* and *youse* are used as plural forms:

Example 1.3.9. *I know what some of yous might be thinking.*

Another plural form is *you people*.
However, this can sound rude, and should only be used if you want to show that you are angry or annoyed with the people you are talking to.

Example 1.3.10. *'Why can't you people leave me alone?' he says.*
'I can't work with you people,' Zoe said.

Some plural forms of *you* - *you guys, you lot, you 2, you 3* and *y'all* - can be used as **vocatives**.
For more information on vocatives, see paragraphs **9.95–9.99**.
You all and *you both* cannot be used as vocatives.

Example 1.3.11. *'Listen, you guys,' she said. 'I'll tell you everything you want.'*
Come on, you 2. Let's go home.
Bye, y'all!

For more information on *you* as an **object pronoun**, see paragraphs **1.104–1.106**.
1.99 You refer to a man or a boy as *he*, and to a woman or a girl as *she*.

Example 1.3.12. *My father is 78, and he's very healthy and independent.*
Billy Knight was a boxer, wasn't he?
Mary came in. She was a good-looking woman.
'Is Sue there?' - 'I'm sorry, she doesn't work here now.'

1.100 You use *it* to refer to anything that is not male or female; e.g., an object, a place, an organization, or something abstract.

Example 1.3.13. *Have you seen Toy Story? It's a good film for kids.*
'Have you been to London?' - 'Yes, it was very crowded.'
How much would the company be worth if it were sold?
It is not an idea that has much public support.

It is often used to refer to an animal when its gender is not known or not considered to be important.
Some people also refer to babies in this way.

Example 1.3.14. *They punched the crocodile until it let go of her.*
If the shark is still around it will not escape.
How Winifred loved the baby! And how Stephanie hated it!

You also use *it* in general statements, e.g. to refer to a situation, the time, the date, or the weather.

Example 1.3.15. *It is very quiet here.*
It is half past 3.
It is Jan 19th.
It is rainy and cold.

For more information on the use of *it* in general statements, see paragraphs **9.31–9.45**.
Note that *it* is also an **object pronoun**.
For more information on this, see paragraphs **1.104–1.106**.
[i] Usage note.
1.101 Although *it* is used as a pronoun to refer to something that is not male or female, *she* is sometimes used to refer to ships, cars, and countries.
Some people do not like this usage.

Example 1.3.16. *When the repairs had been done she was a fine and beautiful ship.*

1.102 You use *we* to refer to a group of people that includes yourself.
The group can be:

- you can the person or people you are talking to

  Example 1.3.17. *Where shall we meet, Sally?*

- you and the person or people you are talking to and 1 or more others not there at the time

  Example 1.3.18. *We aren't exactly gossips, you and I and Watson.*

- you and 1 or more other people, but not including the person or people you are talking to

  Example 1.3.19. *I do the washing; he does the cooking; we share the washing-up.*

- any group that you feel yourself to be part of, e.g. a school, your local community, or even mankind as a whole.

  For more information on this, see paragraph **1.122**.

1.103 You use *they* to refer to a group of things, or to a group of people not including yourself or the person or people you are talking to.

Example 1.3.20. *All the girls think he's great, don't they?*
Newspapers reach me on the day after they are published.
Winters here vary as they do elsewhere.

They is also used to refer to people in general.
For more information on this, see paragraph **1.123**.
1.104 Object pronouns refer to the same sets of people or things as the corresponding subject pronouns.
Here is a table of object pronouns:

	singular	**plural**
1st person	me	us
2nd person	you	you
3rd person	him, her, it	them

1.105 Object pronouns are used as the object of a clause.

Example 1.3.21. *The nurse washed me with cold water.*
He likes you; he said so.
The man went up to the cat and started stroking it.

They can be the indirect object of a clause.

Example 1.3.22. *Send us card so we'll know where you are.*
A man gave him a car.
You have to offer them some kind of incentive.

They can also be the object of a preposition.

Example 1.3.23. *She must have felt intimidated by me.*
Madeleine, I want to talk to you immediately.
We were all sitting in a café with him.

1.106 Object pronouns can also be used after **linking verbs**.
E.g., you can say *It was me, It's her.*
However, in formal or written English, people sometimes use a subject pronoun after a linking verb.
E.g., *It was I, It is she.*
For more information on linking verbs, see paragraphs **3.126–3.181**.

1.3.2 Talking about possession: possessive pronouns

1.107 When you are talking about people or things, you often want to say how they are connected with each other.
There are several different ways in which you can do this, but you usually do it by using a **possessive pronoun** to show that something belongs to someone or is associated with them.
Here is a table showing possessive pronouns:

	singular	**plural**
1st person	mine	ours
2nd person	yours	yours
3rd person	his, hers	theirs

Note that *its* cannot be used as a possessive pronoun.
1.108 You use possessive pronouns when you are talking about the same type of thing that has just been mentioned but want to show that it belongs to someone else.
E.g., in the sentence *Jane showed them her passport, then Richard showed them his*, *his* refers to a passport and shows that it belongs to Richard.
Possessive pronouns are often used to contrast 2 things of the same type that belong to or are associated with different people.
E.g., *Sarah's house is much bigger than ours.*

Example 1.3.24. *Her parents were in Malaya, and so were mine.*
He smiled at her and laid his hand on hers.
Is that coffee yours or mine?
My marks were higher than his.
Fred put his profits in the bank, while Julia spent hers on a car.
That's the difference between his ideas and ours.
It was his fault, not theirs.

1.109 Possessive pronouns are used with *of* to add information to a noun phrase.
This structure suggests that you are talking about 1 of a group of things.
E.g., if you say *a friend of mine* you are talking about 1 of a number of friends whereas if you say *my friend* you are talking about 1 friend in particular.

Example 1.3.25. *He was an old friend of mine.*
A student of yours has just been to see me.
David Lodge? I've just read a novel of his.
It was hinted to him by some friends of hers.
The room was not a favorite of theirs.

1.110 For other ways of showing that something belongs to someone or is connected with them, see paragraphs **1.211–1.221**.

1.3.3 Referring back to the subject: reflexive pronouns

1.111 When you want to show that the object or the indirect object of a verb is the same person or thing as the subject of the verb, you use a **reflexive pronoun**.

Some verbs are very frequently used with reflexive pronouns.

For information about these, see paragraphs **3.26–3.31**.

Here is a table of reflexive pronouns:

	singular	**plural**
1st person	myself	ourselves
2nd person	yourself	yourselves
3rd person	himself, herself, itself	themselves

[!] Be careful.

1.112 Unlike personal pronouns and possessive pronouns, there are 2 forms of the reflexive pronoun used for the 2nd person.

You use *yourself* when you are talking to 1 person.

You use *yourselves* when you are talking to more than 1 person, or referring to a group that includes the person you are talking to.

1.113 You use a reflexive pronoun to make it clear that the object of a verb is the same person or thing as the subject of the verb, or to emphasize this.

E.g., *John killed himself* means that John did the killing, and he was also the person who was killed.

Example 1.3.26. *He forced himself to remain absolutely still.*
She stretched herself out on the sofa.
I'm sure history repeats itself.
We all shook hands and introduced ourselves.
The boys formed themselves into a line.
Here is the question you have to ask yourselves.

You also use reflexive pronouns to show or emphasize that the indirect object of a verb is the same person or thing as the subject of the verb.

E.g., in the sentence *Ann poured herself a drink*, Ann did the pouring and she was also the person who the drink was for.

Example 1.3.27. *Here's the money, you can go and buy yourself a watch.*

[!] Be careful.

1.114 Reflexive pronouns are not usually used with actions that people normally do to themselves, e.g. washing, dressing, or shaving.

So you do not usually say *He shaves himself every morning.*

You can, however, sometimes use reflexive pronouns with these actions for emphasis, or to talk about a surprising event, e.g. a child doing something that they were not previously able to do.

1.115 If the subject of a clause and the object of a preposition refer to the same person, and the clause does not have a direct object, you use a reflexive pronoun after the preposition.

Example 1.3.28. *I was thoroughly ashamed of myself.*
Barbara stared at herself in the mirror.
We think of ourselves as members of the local community.
They can't cook for themselves.

However, if the clause does have a direct object, you usually use a personal pronoun after the preposition.

Example 1.3.29. *I will take it home with me.*
They put the book between them on the kitchen table.
I shivered and drew the rug around me.
Mrs Bixby went out, slamming the door behind her.

Note that if the clause has a direct object and it is not obvious that the subject of the clause and the object of the preposition refer to the same person, you use a reflexive pronoun.

E.g., *The Managing Director gave the biggest pay rise to himself.*

1.116 Especially in speech, people sometimes use reflexive pronouns rather than personal pronouns as the object of a preposition, in order to emphasize them.

Example 1.3.30. *... people like myself who are politically active.*
... the following conversation between myself and a 15-year-old girl.
The circle spread to include himself and Ferdinand.
People like yourself still find new things to say about Shakespeare.
There is always someone worse off than yourself.
With the exception of a few Algerians and ourselves, everyone spoke Spanish.

1.117 You can use reflexive pronouns in addition to nouns to personal pronouns.
You usually do this in order to make it clear or to emphasize who or what you are referring to.

Example 1.3.31. *I myself sometimes say things I don't mean.*
Sally herself came back.

You also use a reflexive pronoun to compare or contrast 1 person or thing with another.

Example 1.3.32. *His friend looked as miserable as he felt himself.*
It is not Des Moines I miss, but Iowa itself.

The reflexive pronoun follows the noun or pronoun that it relates to.

Example 1.3.33. *It is hot in London; but I myself can work better when it's hot.*
The town itself was so small that it didn't have a priest.
The lane ran right up to the wood itself.

It can also be placed at the end of the clause.

Example 1.3.34. *I am not a particularly punctual person myself.*
You'll probably understand better when you are a grandparent yourself.
It is rare for Governments to take the initiative themselves.

1.118 You use a reflexive pronoun to emphasize that someone did something without any help or interference from anyone else.
In this use, the reflexive pronoun is normally placed at the end of the clause.

Example 1.3.35. *She had printed the card herself.*
I'll take it down to the police station myself.
Did you make these yourself?

1.3.4 People in general: generic pronouns

1.119 When you want to talk about people in general, you can use a **generic pronoun**.
Here is a list of pronouns that can be used as generic pronouns:

Subject	you	one	we	they
Object	you	one	us	them
Possessive	yours	-	ours	theirs
Reflexive	yourself	oneself	ourselves	themselves

1.120 *You* is sometimes used to make statements about people in general, or about a person in a situation that you are imaging.
You is used in this way in both subject and object position.
The possessive form *yours* and the reflexive form *yourself* can also be used as generic pronouns.

Example 1.3.36. *To be a good doctor you need to have good communication skills.*
Champagne can give you a headache.
Once you've bought a physical book, you own it: you can lend it to people, donate it, and, well, it's yours.
When you live alone you have to force yourself to go out more.

In informal English, you can use *you get* or *you have* to make a general statement about something that exists in the world.

Example 1.3.37. *You get some old people who are very difficult.*
Anytime you have over 8 inches of snow, driving becomes problematic.

1.121 In formal writing, *one* is sometimes used instead of *you*.
Once can be used in subject or object position.
The reflexive form *oneself* is also used, but there is no possessive pronoun form of *one*.

Example 1.3.38. *Going round Italy, one is struck by the number of opera houses there are.*
This scene makes one realize how deeply this community has been afflicted.
If one puts oneself up for public office, then it is inappropriate that one should behave badly.

1.122 You can refer to a general group that includes yourself as *we* or, in object position, *us*.
This group can be all of mankind, or it can be smaller group e.g. a nation or a community.
The possessive form *ours* and the reflexive form *ourselves* can also be used in this way.

Example 1.3.39. *We all need money.*
This survey gives us insight into our attitudes and behavior as a nation.
No other language has ever advanced as far, as fast, as ours.
We need a change of government; just riding ourselves of the prime minister isn't enough.

1.123 You can use *they* to refer to people in general.

Example 1.3.40. *Isn't that what they call love?*

They can also refer to a group of people whose identity does not need to be stated.
E.g., in the sentence *They've given John another pay rise* it is clear that *they* refers to John's employers.

Example 1.3.41. *'Don't worry', I said to Mother, 'they are moving you from this ward soon.'*

You can also use *they* in subject position, or *them* in object position, to refer to an individual when you do not know, or do not want to specify, whether the individual is male or female.
The possessive form *theirs* and the reflexive form *themselves* can also be used in this way.
This use is very common after:

- the **indefinite pronouns** *anyone, anybody, someone* and *somebody*.

  These are explained in paragraphs **1.128–1.141**.

- singular nouns e.g. *person, parent* and *teacher*, which do not specify whether the person is male or female

  - If anyone wants to be a childminder, they must attend a course.
    If I think someone is having problems, I will spend hours talking to them.
    A person's body fat determines how long they can withstand cold water.

Note that the plural form of the verb is always used after *they*, even when it refers to only 1 person.
You can also use *they, them, theirs* and *themselves* to refer to:

- the **indefinite pronouns** *everyone, everybody, no one* and *nobody*.

  These are explained in paragraphs **1.128–1.141**.

- noun phrases with the determiners *each, every* and *any*.

In these cases, although the pronouns or noun phrases are grammatically singular, they refer to groups of people.

Example 1.3.42. *I never avoid my obligations and I expect everyone else to meet theirs.*
Each parent was sent an individual letter informing them of the situation.
We want every player to push themselves to get into the team.

Another way is to use *he or she* instead of *they, him or her* instead of *them, himself or herself* instead of *themselves* and *his or hers* instead of *theirs*.
This is often used in formal or written English.

Example 1.3.43. *Would a young person be able to get a job in Europe? That would depend on which country he or she wanted to go to.*
The student should feel that the essay belongs to him or her.

Some people use *he* and *him* in general statements or after indefinite pronouns, but many people object to this use because it suggests that person being referred to is male.

1.3.5 Referring to a particular person or thing: *this, that, these* and *those*

1.125 When *this, that, these*, and *those* are used as pronouns, they are used as the subject or the object of a clause, or the object of a preposition.

Demonstrative pronouns are rarely used as the indirect object of a clause, because the indirect object is usually a person, and demonstrative pronouns normally refer to things.

1.125 *This* and *that* are usually used as pronouns only when they refer to things.

You use them instead of a singular countable noun or an uncountable noun.

This refers to something that is close to you in place or time, and *that* refers to something that is more distant in place or time.

Example 1.3.44. *This is a list of the rules.*
This is the most important part of the job.
The biggest problem was the accent. That was difficult for me.
That looks interesting.

1.126 *This* and *that* are used as pronouns to refer to a person when you are identifying someone or asking who they are.

Example 1.3.45. *Who's this?*
He stopped and looked at a photograph that stood on the dressing table. Is this your wife?
Was that Patrick on the phone?

When you are introducing people, you can say *This is Mary* or *This is Mr and Mrs Baker.*

Note that you use *this* even when you are introducing more than 1 person.

1.127 *These* and *those* can be used as pronouns instead of a plural countable noun.

They are most often used to refer to things, although they can be used to refer to people.

These refers to a number of people and things that are close to you in place or time, and *those* refers to a number of people and things that are more distant in place or time.

Example 1.3.46. *'I brought you these.' Adam held out a bag of grapes.*
Vitamin tablets usually contain vitamins A, C, and D. These are available from any child health clinic.
These are no ordinary students.
It may be impossible for them to pay essential bills, e.g. those for heating.
Those are easy questions to answer.
There are a lot of people who are seeking employment, and a great number of those are married women.

This, that, these, and *those* can also be **definite determiners**.

For more information, see paragraphs **1.184–1.193**.
See also *Referring back* and *Referring forward* in Chap. 10.

1.3.6 Referring to people & things in a non-specific way: *someone, anyone, everyone*, etc.

1.128 When you want to refer to people or things but you do not know exactly who or what they are, or their identity is not important, you can use an **indefinite pronoun** e.g. *someone, anyone*, or *everyone.*

An indefinite pronoun shows only whether you are talking about people or about things, rather than referring to a specific person or thing.

Example 1.3.47. *I was there for over an hour before anybody came.*
Jack was waiting for something.

Here is a list of indefinite pronouns:

Example 1.3.48. *I was there for over an hour before anybody came.*
Jack was waiting for something.

Here is a list of indefinite pronouns:

Example 1.3.49. *anybody, anyone, anything, everybody, everyone, everything, nobody, no one, nothing, somebody, someone, something*

[**AE**] Note that all indefinite pronouns are written as 1 word except *no one.*

It is always 2 words in American English, but in British English it can also be spelled with a hyphen: *no-one.*

1.129 You always use singular verbs with indefinite pronouns.

Example 1.3.50. *Is anyone here?*
Everybody recognizes the importance of education.
Everything was ready.
Nothing is certain in this world.

1.130 You use the indefinite pronouns ending in *-thing* to talk about objects, ideas, situations, or activities.

Example 1.3.51. *Can I do anything?*
Jane said nothing for a moment.

1.131 You use the indefinite pronouns ending in *-one* and *-body* to refer to people.

Example 1.3.52. *It had to be someone like Dan.*
Why does everybody believe in the law of gravity?

Note that indefinite pronouns ending in *-body* are more frequent in informal English.
1.132 Although you use singular verbs with indefinite pronouns, if you want to refer back to an indefinite pronoun, you use the plural pronouns *they, them*, or *themselves*, or the possessive determiner *their*.

Example 1.3.53. *Ask anyone. They'll tell you.*
There's no way of telling somebody why they've failed.
No one liked being young then as they do now.
Everybody's enjoying themselves.
Everyone put their pens down.

See paragraph **1.123** for more information about *they* used to refer to 1 person.
[i] Usage note.
1.133 In more formal English, some people prefer to use *he, him, his*, or *himself* to refer back to an indefinite pronoun, but many people dislike this use because it suggests that the person being referred to is male.

Example 1.3.54. *If someone consistently eats a lot of fatty foods, it is not surprising if he ends up with clogged arteries.*
Everybody has his dream.

For other ways of using pronouns when you do not want to specify whether the person you are talking about is male or female, see paragraph **1.123**.
1.134 You add *'s* (apostrophe *s*) to indefinite pronoun to refer to things that belong to or are associated with people.

Example 1.3.55. *She was given a room in someone's studio.*
That was nobody's business.
I would defend anyone's rights.
Everything has been arranged to everybody's satisfaction.

[!] Be careful.
1.135 You do not usually add *'s* to indefinite pronouns referring to things.
So, e.g., you would be more likely to say *the value of something* than *something's value*.
1.136 When you want to give more information about the person or thing referred to by an indefinite pronoun, you can use a phrase or a clause after it.

Example 1.3.56. *Anyone over the age of 18 can apply.*
He would prefer to have somebody who had a background in the humanities.

1.137 You can also use adjectives to add information.
Note that adjectives are placed after the indefinite pronoun rather than in front of it, and that you do not use a determiner.
You do not say *an important someone*, you say *someone important*.

Example 1.3.57. *What was needed was someone practical.*
They are doing everything possible to take care of you.
There is nothing wrong with being popular.

1.138 If you have already mentioned a person or thing, and you want to refer to a different person or thing, or an additional one, you use *else* after an indefinite pronoun.

Example 1.3.58. *Somebody else will have to go out there.*
She couldn't think of anything else.
Everyone knows what everyone else is doing.
He got that job because nobody else wanted it.

Note that if you want to show association or possession with an indefinite pronoun and *else*, you add the *'s* to *else*.

Example 1.3.59. *Problems always became someone else's fault.*
No one has control over anyone else's career.

1.139 Just like nouns, indefinite pronouns are the subject, object, or indirect object of clauses.
They can also be used as the objects of prepositions.
The indefinite pronouns beginning with *some-* and *every-* are most often used in affirmative clauses.

Example 1.3.60. *Everything went according to plan.*
I remember somebody putting a pillow under my head.
'Now you'll see something,' he said.
I gave everyone a generous helping.
I want to introduce you to someone who is helping me.
Is everything all right?

They are sometimes used as the subject of a negative clause.

Example 1.3.61. *He could tell that something wasn't right.*

Note that the indefinite pronouns beginning with *some-* cannot be used as the object of a negative clause, unless they are followed by a phrase or a clause.

Example 1.3.62. *He wasn't someone I admired as a writer.*

1.140 Indefinite pronouns beginning with *any-* can be used as the object or indirect object of a question or a negative clause.

Example 1.3.63. *Don't worry - I won't tell anyone.*
You still haven't told me anything.
Take a good look and tell me if you see anything different.
I haven't given anyone their presents yet.

They are often used as the subject of both negative and affirmative questions.
Note that they are not used as the subject of a negative statement.
You do not say, e.g., *Anybody can't come in.*

Example 1.3.64. *Does anybody agree with me?*
Won't anyone help me?
If anything unusual happens, could you call me on this number?

Note that when you are making an affirmative statement, *anyone* and *anybody* are used to refer to people in general and not to only 1 person.

Example 1.3.65. *Anybody who wants to can come in and buy a car from me.*

1.141 Indefinite pronouns beginning with *no-* are always used with the affirmative form of a verb, and they make the clause negative.
For more information on **negative statements**, see paragraphs **5.49–5.93**.

Example 1.3.66. *Nobody said a word.*
There was nothing you could do, nothing at all.
She was to see no one, to speak to nobody, not even her own children.

Note that they are sometimes used in questions.
When this is the case, the answer to the question is usually expected to be *no*.

Example 1.3.67. *'Is there nothing I can do?' - 'Not a thing'.*
'Is there nobody else?' - 'Not that I know of'.

1.3.7 Showing that people do the same thing: *each other* & *one another*

1.142 *Each other* and *one another* are called **reciprocal pronouns**.

They are used to say that people do the same thing, feel the same way, or have the same relationship.

E.g., if your brother hates your sister and your sister hates your brother, you can say *My brother and sister hate each other* or *They hate one another.*

Reciprocal pronouns are not used as the subject of a clause.

You can use them as the object or indirect object of a verb.

Example 1.3.68. *We help each other a lot.*
You and I understand each other.
We support one another through good times and bad.
They sent each other gifts from time to time.

You also use them as the object of a preposition.

Example 1.3.69. *Terry and Mark were jealous of each other.*
The 2 lights were moving towards one another.
They didn't dare to look at one another.

Some verbs are very commonly used with reciprocal pronouns.

For more information about these, see paragraphs **3.68**–**3.72**.

1.143 Note that there is very little difference between *each other* and *one another.*

They are both used to talk about 2 or more people or things, although some people prefer the use of *each other* when there are only 2 people or things, and *one another* when there are more than 2.

1.144 In formal written English, you can also use *each* as the subject of a clause and *the other* as the object of a clause or preposition.

So, a more formal way of saying *They looked at each other* is *Each looked at the other.*

Note that *each* is always followed by a singular verb.

Example 1.3.70. *Each accuses the other of lying.*
Each is unwilling to learn from the experience of the others.

Each is also a determiner.

For more information about this, see paragraph **1.243**.

1.145 You add *'s* (apostrophe *s*) to *each other, one another*, and *the other* to form possessives.

Example 1.3.71. *I hope that you all enjoy each other's company.*
Apes spend a great deal of time grooming one another's fur.
The males fight fiercely, each trying to seize the other's long neck in its beak.

1.3.8 Joining clauses together: relative pronouns

1.146 When a sentence consists of a main clause followed by a **relative clause** introduced by *who, whom, which*, or *that*, these words are called **relative pronouns**.

Relative pronouns do 2 things at the same time.

Like other pronouns, they refer to someone or something that has already been mentioned.

At the same time they join clauses together.

For more information about relative clauses, see paragraphs **8.83**–**8.116**.

1.147 *Who* and *whom* always refer to people.

Who can be the subject of a relative clause.

Example 1.3.72. *... mathematicians who are concerned with very difficult problems.*

In the past, *whom* was normally used as the object of a relative clause.

Nowadays, *who* is more often used, although some careful speakers of English think that this is more correct to use *whom.*

Example 1.3.73. *... a man who I met recently.*
He's the man who I saw last night.
... 2 girls whom I met in Edinburgh.

Who is sometimes used as the object of a preposition when the object is separated from the preposition.

Some careful speakers think that it is more correct to use *whom.*

Example 1.3.74. *That's the man who I gave it to.*
... those whom we cannot talk to.

Whom is almost always used when the object comes immediately after the preposition.

Example 1.3.75. *... Lord Scarman, a man for whom I have immense respect.*

1.148 *Which* always refers to things.
It can be used as the subject or object of a relative clause, or as the object of a preposition.
Which is often used in British English to introduce relative clauses that refer to things.

Example 1.3.76. *... a region which was threatened by growing poverty.*
... 2 horses which he owned.
... the house in which I was born.

Note that which cannot be used as the indirect object of a clause.
1.149 *That* refers to either people or things.
It is used as the subject or the object of a relative clause or the object of a preposition.
That is generally preferred in American English to introduce relative clauses that refer to things or to combinations of people and things.

Example 1.3.77. *... the games that politicians play.*
He's the boy that sang the solo last night.
It was the 1st bed that she had ever slept in.

That cannot be used as the indirect object of a clause.
1.150 *Whose* shows who or what something belongs to or is connected with.
Note that it cannot be used by itself, but must come in front of a noun.

Example 1.3.78. *... the thousands whose lives have been damaged.*
There was a chap there whose name I've forgotten.
... predictions whose accuracy will have to be determined.
... sharks, whose brains are minute.

Note that *whose* is not restricted to people.

1.3.9 Asking questions: interrogative pronouns

1.151 1 way of asking questions i by using an **interrogative pronoun**.
The interrogative pronouns are *who, whose, whom, what*, and *which*.
They are used as the subject or object of a clause, or as the object of a preposition.
Whose and *which* are also determiners.
Other words, e.g. *where, when, why*, and *how*, are also used to ask questions.
Interrogative pronouns are not used as the indirect object of a clause.

Example 1.3.79. *Who was at the door?*
'There's a cat outside.' - 'Whose is it?'
Whom do you support?
Which is best, gas or electric?

For more information about structures in which interrogative pronouns are used, see paragraphs **5.10–5.36**.
1.152 Interrogative pronouns refer to the information you are asking for.
Who, whose, and *whom* are used when you think that the answer to the question will be a person.

Example 1.3.80. *'He lost his wife.' - 'Who? Terry?'*
He looked at the cat. Whose is it? Have you ever seen it before?
'To whom, if I may ask, are you engaged to be married?' - 'To Danial Orton.'

Which and *what* are used when you think that the answer to the question will be something other than a person.

Example 1.3.81. *Is there really a difference? Which do you prefer?*
'What did he want?' - 'Maurice's address.'

1.153 Interrogative pronouns are also used to introduce reported questions.

Example 1.3.82. *I asked her who she had been talking to.*
He wondered what Daintry would do now.

For more information about **reported questions**, see paragraphs **7.32–7.38**.

1.3.10 Other pronouns

1.154 Many other words can be pronouns, provided that it is clear what is being talked about, because it is then unnecessary to repeat the noun.

E.g., most **indefinite determiners** can also be pronouns.

For more information about indefinite determiners, see paragraphs **1.223–1.250**.

Here is a list of indefinite determiners that are also pronouns:

Example 1.3.83. *all, another, any, both, each, either, enough, few, fewer, less, little, many, more, most, much, neither, several, some*

Like all noun phrases, they can be used as the subject, direct object, or indirect object of a clause, or the object of a preposition.

Example 1.3.84. *Both were offered jobs immediately.*
Children? I don't think she has any.
I saw 1 girl whispering to another.

1.155 Although *a, an, every*, and *no* are indefinite determiners, they cannot stand alone as pronouns.

To refer back to a noun phrase that includes the determiner *a* or *an*, you can use the pronoun *one*.

Similarly, you use *each* to refer back to a noun phrase that includes *every*, and *none* to refer back to a noun phrase that includes *no*.

Note that *another* and *others* are pronouns, but *other* cannot be a pronoun.

1.156 *All, both*, and *each* can be used in addition to nouns or personal pronouns for emphasis, in a similar way to use of **reflexive pronouns** described in paragraphs **1.116–1.118**.

Example 1.3.85. *The brothers all agreed that something more was needed.*
He loved them both.
Ford and Duncan each had their chances.

They come after an auxiliary verb, a model, or *be*.

Example 1.3.86. *They were both still working at their universities.*
The letters have all been signed.
The older children can all do the same things together.

Each can also come at the end of the clause.

Example 1.3.87. *3 others were fined £200 each.*

1.157 **Numbers** can also be pronouns.

E.g., the answer to the question *How many children do you have?* is usually *3* rather than *3 children*.

Example 1.3.88. *'How many people are there?' - '45.'*
Of the other women, 2 are dancers.
They bought 8 companies and sold of 5.

For more information on numbers, see paragraphs **2.213–2.231**.

1.158 The number *one* is a special case.

Like other numbers, it is sometimes used to refer to 1 of a group of things.

One is also used to refer back to a noun phrase with the determiner *a*.

Example 1.3.89. *Could I have a bigger one, please?*

It can also be used for emphasis after another determiner.

Example 1.3.90. *There are systems of communication right through the animal world; each one is distinctive.*

One can be used as a **personal pronoun**.

This use is explained in paragraph **1.121**.

1.159 Note that *the one* and *the ones* can be used to refer to a noun alone, rather than to the whole of the noun phrase.

They are nearly always used with a modifier e.g. an adjective, or some form of information after the noun, e.g. a prepositional phrase.

Example 1.3.91. *'Which poem?' - 'The one they were talking about yesterday.'*
There are 3 bedrooms. Mine is the one at the back.
He gave the best seats to the ones who arrived 1st.

1.160 You use *the other, the others, others*, or *another* to refer to different members of a group of things or people.

Example 1.3.92. *Some writers are greater than others.*
1 runner was way ahead of all the others.

1.161 If you want to say something about a member of a group of people or things you can use *one*.
You can then refer to the rest of the group as *the others*.

Example 1.3.93. *The bells are carefully installed so that disconnecting one will have no effect on the others.*
They had 3 little daughters, one a baby, the others twins of 12.

You use *the one* and *the other* to refer to each of a pair of things.

Example 1.3.94. *The same factors push wages and prices up together, the one reinforcing the other.*

If you do not wish to specify exactly which of a group you are talking about, you refer to *one or other* of them.

Example 1.3.95. *It may be that one or other of them had fears for their health.*

1.4 Definite & indefinite determiners

1.162 In English, there are 2 main ways in which you can use a **noun phrase**.
You can use it to refer to someone or something, knowing that the person you are speaking to understands which person or thing you are talking about.

Example 1.4.1. *The man began to run towards the boy.*
Young people don't like these operas.
Thank you very much for your comments.
. . . a visit to the Houses of Parliament.

Alternatively, you can use a noun phrase to refer to someone or something of a particular type, without saying which person or thing you mean.

Example 1.4.2. *There was a man in the lift.*
I wish I'd bought an umbrella.
Any doctor would say she didn't know what she was doing.

In order to distinguish between these 2 ways of using a noun phrase, you use a special class of words called **determiners**.
There are 2 types of determiner, **definite determiners** and **indefinite determiners**.
You put them at the beginning of a noun phrase.

1.4.1 Using the definite determiner *the*

1.163 *The* is the most common definite determiner; it is sometimes called the **definite article**.
This, that, these, and *those* are often called **demonstratives** or **demonstrative adjectives**.
For more information on these, see paragraphs **1.184–1.193**.
My, your, his, her, its, our and *their* are **possessive determiners**.
They are also sometimes called **possessive adjectives** or just **possessives**.
For more information about these, see paragraphs **1.194–1.210**.
Here is the list of definite determiners:

Example 1.4.3. *the*
this, that, these, those
my, your, his, her, its, our, their

Note that in English you cannot use more than 1 definite determiner before a noun.
1.164 Because *the* is the most common definite determiner, you can put *the* in front of any common noun.

Example 1.4.4. *She dropped the can into the grass.*
The girls were not in the house.

In these examples, the use of *the can* means that a can has already been mentioned; *the grass* is definite because it has already been stated that *she* is outside, and the presence of grass may also have been stated or is presumed; *the girls*, like *the can*, must have been mentioned before; and *the house* means the one where the girls were staying at the time.
1.165 *The* always has the same spelling, but it has 3 different pronunciations:

- /ðə/ when the following word begins with a consonant sound

  Example 1.4.5. *... the dictionary... the 1st act... the big box*

- /ði/ when the following word begins with a vowel sound

  Example 1.4.6. *... the exhibition... the effect... the impression*

- /ðiː/ when it is emphasized

  Example 1.4.7. *You don't mean the Ernest Hemingway?*

See paragraph **1.181** for more information about emphatic uses of *the*.

1.166 You can use a noun phrase consisting just of *the* and a noun when you know that the person you are talking or writing to will understand which person, thing, or group you are referring to.

Example 1.4.8. *The expedition sailed out into the Pacific.*
... the most obnoxious boy in the school.
He stopped the car in front of the bakery.

1.167 Some nouns are used with *the* because they refer to only 1 person, thing, or group.

Some of these are specific names or **proper nouns**, e.g. titles e.g. *the Pope*, unique things e.g. *the Eiffel Tower*, and place names e.g. *the Atlantic*.

Example 1.4.9. *... a concert attended by the Queen.*
We went on camel rides to the Pyramids.

See paragraphs **1.52–1.58** for more information about proper nouns.

Some are **singular nouns**, that is they refer to something of which there is only 1 in the world, e.g. *the ground*, or *the moon*.

Example 1.4.10. *The sun began to turn red.*
In Apr and May the wind blows steadily.

See paragraphs **1.34–1.40** for more information about singular nouns.

1.168 Other nouns are used to talk about just 1 person, thing, or group in a particular place or organization, so that if you are talking about that place or organization or talking to someone in it, you can use just *the* and the noun.

E.g., if there is only 1 station in a town, the people who live in the town will talk about *the station*.

Similarly, people living in Britain talk to each other about *the economy*, meaning *the British economy*, and people working for the same organization might talk about *the boss, the union*, or *the canteen* without needing to specify the organization.

Example 1.4.11. *The church has been broken into.*
There's a wind coming off the river.
We had to get rid of the director.
The mayor is a 48-year-old former laborer.
What is the President doing about all this?

1.169 Normally, if you want to talk generally about all people or things of a particular type, you use the plural form of a noun without a determiner.

However, there are some countable nouns that are used in the singular with *the* to refer to something more general.

E.g., you can use *the theater* or *the stage* to talk about all entertainment performed in theaters.

Similarly, *the screen* refers to films in general, and *the law* refers to the system of laws in a country.

Example 1.4.12. *For him, the stage was just a way of earning a living.*
He was as handsome in real life as he was on the screen.
They do not hesitate to break the law.

Some nouns that normally refer to an individual thing or person can be used in the singular with *the* to refer generally to a system or service in a particular place.

E.g., you can use *the bus* to talk about a bus service and *the phone* to talk about a telephone system.

Example 1.4.13. *How long does it take on the train?*
We rang for the ambulance.

Nouns referring to musical instruments can be used in the singular with *the* when you are talking about someone playing, or being able to play, a particular kind of instrument.

Example 1.4.14. *You play the oboe, I see, said Simon.*
I was playing the piano when he phoned.

1.170 When you want to talk generally about groups of people who share the same characteristic or quality, you often choose an adjective preceded by *the*.

Example 1.4.15. *This project is all about giving employment to the unemployed.*

See paragraphs **.166–1.72** for more information about using adjectives as nouns.
1.171 Nouns referring to plants and animals can be used in the singular with *the* when you are making a statement about every member of a species.
E.g., if you say *The swift has long, narrow wings*, you mean that all swifts have long, narrow wings.

Example 1.4.16. *The primrose can grow abundantly on chalk banks.*
Australia is the home of the kangaroo.

Similarly, a noun referring to a part of the human body can be used with *the* to refer to that part of anyone's body.

Example 1.4.17. *These arteries supply the heart with blood.*
. . . the arteries supplying the kidneys.

The is sometimes used with other nouns in the singular to make a statement about all the members of a group.

Example 1.4.18. *The article focuses on how to protect the therapist rather than on how to cure the patient.*

These uses are fairly formal.
They are not common in ordinary speech.
Usually, if you want to make a statement about all the things of a particular kind, you use the plural form of a noun without a determiner.
See paragraph **1.227** for more information about this.
[i] Usage note.
1.172 Many common time expressions consist of just *the* and a noun.

Example 1.4.19. *We wasted a lot of money in the past.*
The train leaves Cardiff at 4 in the afternoon.
. . . the changes which are taking place at the moment.

See Chap. 4 for more information about time expressions.
1.173 In each of the paragraphs above showing uses of *the* and a noun, it is possible to understand who or what is being referred to because the noun phrase is commonly accepted as referring to 1 particular person, thing, or group.
However, you can use *the* with any noun, if it is obvious who or what you are referring to from what has already been said or written.
The usual way of referring back to a noun is to use a pronoun, but if the 2nd reference does not come immediately after the 1st one, or if it is not immediately obvious which noun is being referred to, you should use *the*, and the noun again.
E.g., if you have already mentioned that you were in a train, and then continued to tell a story, you can say afterwards *The train suddenly stopped.*
1.174 You can also use *the* and a noun when you are referring to someone or something closely connected with something you have just mentioned.
E.g., you do not usually say *We tried to get into the room, but the door of the room was locked.*
You say *We tried to get into the room, but the door was locked*, because it is obvious which door you are referring to.

Example 1.4.20. *She stopped and lit a match. The wind almost blew out the flame.*

1.175 Although there are many situations where you use just *the* and a noun, there are other occasions when you need to add something else to the noun in order to make it clear which person, thing, or group you are referring to.
1.176 Sometimes you can show who or what you are referring to by putting an **adjective** between *the* and the noun.

Example 1.4.21. *This is the main bedroom.*
Somebody ought to have done it long ago, remarked the fat man.

Sometimes you need to use more than 1 adjective.

Example 1.4.22. *After the crossroads look out for the large white building.*

For more information about adjectives, see paragraphs **2.2–2.168**.

1.177 When you use an adjective between *the* and a noun, you do not always do it in order to make clear who or what is being referred to.

E.g., you might want to add further information about someone or something that you have already mentioned.

So, if you 1st refer to someone as *a woman* in a sentence e.g. *A woman came into the room*, you might later want to refer to her as *the unfortunate woman* or *the smiling woman.*

This is a very common use in written English, especially in stories, but it is not often used in conversation.

Example 1.4.23. *The astonished waiter was now watching from the other end of the room.*
The poor woman had witnessed terrible violence.
The loss of pressure caused the speeding car to go into a skid.

1.178 Another way of showing who or what you are referring to is buy adding extra information after *the* and a noun, e.g. a prepositional phrase, a relative clause, a *to*-infinitive, an adverb of place or time, or a phrase introduced by a participle.

So you might refer to particular people at a party by using noun phrases e.g. *the girl in the yellow dress, the woman who spilled her drink*, or *the man smoking a cigar.*

Example 1.4.24. *The cars in the driveways were all Ferraris and Porsches.*
The book that I recommend now costs over 20 pounds.
The thing to aim for is an office of your own.
Who made the bed in the room upstairs?
It depends on the person being interviewed.

For more information about this type of extra information that is added to a noun, see paragraphs **2.272–2.302**.

1.179 You do not normally use *the* with **uncountable nouns** because they refer to something in a general way.

However, *the* is necessary if the uncountable noun is followed by extra information e.g. clause or a phrase that relates it to a particular person, thing, or group.

E.g., you cannot say *I am interested in education of young children*,

You have to say *I am interested in the education of young children.*

Example 1.4.25. *Babies need the comfort of their mother's arms.*
Even the honesty of Inspector Butler was in doubt.
I've no idea about the geography of Scotland.

For more information about uncountable nouns, see paragraphs **1.23–1.33**.

1.180 *The* is also used with **superlative adjectives**.

Example 1.4.26. *I'm not the best cook in the world.*
They went to the most expensive restaurant in town.

See paragraphs **2.112–2.122** for more information about superlative adjectives.

1.181 *The* is often used in front of a noun to indicate that someone or something is the best of its kind.

Example 1.4.27. *New Zealand is now the place to visit.*

You can also use *the* in front of a person's name to show that you are referring to the most famous person with that name.

Example 1.4.28. *You actually met the George Harrison?*

When you use *the* in either of these ways, you emphasize it and pronounce it /ðiː/.

1.182 *The* can be used in front of some **indefinite determiners**, usually to give an indication of amount or quantity.

These indefinite determiners are:

Example 1.4.29. *few, little, many, other*

Example 1.4.30. *... pleasures known only to the few.*
... a coup under the leadership of the select few.
He was 1 of the few who knew where to find me.
We have done the little that is in our power.

For more information about indefinite determiners, see paragraphs **1.223–1.250**.

1.183 *The* is used with *one* and *ones.*

Example 1.4.31. *I'm going to have the green one.*
The shop was different from the ones I remembered.
. . . a pair of those old glasses, the ones with those funny square lenses.

The is also used with other **numbers**.

Example 1.4.32. *It is a mistake to confuse the 2.*
Why is she so different from the other 2?

See paragraphs **2.208–2.239** for more information about numbers.

1.4.2 Definite determiners: using *this, that, these*, and *those*

1.184 You use the **definite determiners** *this, that, these*, and *those* to talk about people or things in a definite way.
You use *this* and *these* to talk about people and things that are close to you in place or time.
When you talk about people or things that are more distant in place or time, you use *that* and *those*.
You put *this* and *that* in front of singular nouns, uncountable nouns, and the singular pronoun one.
You put *these* and *those* in front of plural nouns and the plural pronoun *ones*.
This, that, these, and *those* are often called **demonstratives** or **demonstrative adjectives**.
1.185 *This* and *these* are used to talk about people or things that are very obvious in the situation that you are in.
E.g., if you are inside a house, you can refer to it as *this house*.
If you are holding some keys in your hand, you can refer to them as *these keys*.
If you are at a party, you can refer to it as *this party*.

Example 1.4.33. *I have lived in this house my entire life.*
I am going to walk up these steps towards you.
I'll come as soon as these men have finished their work.
I like this university.
Good evening. In this programme we are going to look at the way in which British music has developed in recent years.

When it is clear who or what you are referring to, you can use *this* and *these* as **pronouns**.
This use is explained in paragraphs **1.124–1.127**.
1.186 *This* and *these* are also used in many expressions that refer to current periods of time, e.g. *this month, this week*, and *these days*.
This use is explained in Chap. 4.
1.187 You use *that* and *those* when you are talking about things or people that you can see but that are not close to you.

Example 1.4.34. *How much is it for that big box?*
Can I have one of those brochures?
Can you move those books off there?

1.188 When it is clear who or what you are talking about, you can use *that* and *those* as **pronouns**.
This use is explained in paragraphs **1.124–1.127**.

Example 1.4.35. *Could you just hold that?*
Please don't take those.

[i] Usage note.
1.189 You can show that you are referring to the same person or thing you have just mentioned by using *this, that, these*, or *those* in front of a noun.
E.g., if you have just mentioned a girl, you can refer to her as *this girl* or *that girl* the 2nd time you mention here.
Normally, you use a **pronoun** to refer to someone or something you have just mentioned, but sometimes you cannot do this because it might not be clear who or what the pronoun refers to.

Example 1.4.36. *Students and staff suggest books for the library, and normally we're quite happy to get those books.*
Their house is in a valley. The people in that valley speak about the people in the next valley as foreigners.
They had a lot of diamonds, and they asked her if she could possibly get these diamonds to Britain.

The use of *this, that, those*, etc. to refer again to something that has already been mentioned is fully explained in paragraphs **10.7–10.10**.
1.190 In informal English, you can also use *that* and *those* in front of a noun to talk about people or things that are already known to the person you are speaking or writing to.

Example 1.4.37. *That idiot Antonio has gone and locked our cabin door.*
Have they found those missing children yet?
Do you remember that funny little apartment?

1.191 You can use *that* in front of a noun when you are talking about something that has just happened.

Example 1.4.38. *I knew that meeting would be difficult.*

That is used as a **pronoun** to talk about something that has just happened.
This use is explained in paragraphs **1.124–1.127**.

1.192 In more formal English, *those* can be used instead of *the* in front of a plural noun when the plural noun is followed by a **relative clause**.
In this use, the relative clause specifies exactly which group of people or things are being referred to.

Example 1.4.39. *... those workers who are employed in large enterprises.*
The parents are not afraid to be firm about those matters that seem important to them.

1.193 In informal spoken English, people sometimes use *this* and *these* in front of nouns even when they are mentioning someone or something for the 1st time.

Example 1.4.40. *And then this woman came up to me and she said, I believe you have a goddaughter called Celia Ravenscroft.*
At school we had to wear these awful white cotton hats.

1.4.3 Possessive determiners: *my, your, their*, etc.

1.194 You often want to show that a thing belongs to someone or that it is connected in some way with someone.
1 way of doing this is to use a word like *my, your*, and *their*, which tells you who something belongs to.
These words are called **possessive determiners**.

Example 1.4.41. *Are your children bilingual?*
I remember his name now.
They would be welcome to use our library.
I'd been waiting a long time to park my car.

1.195 There are 7 possessive determiners in English, and each one is associated with a particular personal pronoun:

	singular	**plural**
1st person	my	our
2nd person	your	your
3rd person	his, her, its	their

Personal pronouns are explained in paragraphs **1.95–1.106**.
[!] Be careful.

1.196 You do not spell the possessive *its* with an apostrophe.
It's is short for *it is*.

1.197 Possessive determiners, like other determiners, come after any words like *all* or *some of* (called **predeterminers**), and before any numbers or adjectives.

Example 1.4.42. *... all his letters.*
... their next message.
... my little finger.
... our 2 lifeboats.

See paragraph **1.251** for more information about predeterminers.
[!] Be careful.

1.200 When you want to draw attention to the fact that something belongs or relates to a particular person or thing, you can use the word *own* after the possessive determiner.

Example 1.4.43. *I helped him to some more water but left my own glass untouched.*
Residents are allowed to bring their own furniture with them if they wish to do so.
Make your own decisions.
I heard it with my own ears.
She felt in charge of her own affairs.

If you use a number or adjective in this structure, you put the number or adjective after *own*.

Example 1.4.44. *... their own 3 children.*
The players provided their own white shorts.

1.201 Possessive determiners do not always show that what follows them is actually possessed (or owned) by someone. Sometimes they just show that what follows is connected or associated with someone in some way.

Example 1.4.45. *They then turned their attention to other things.*
... the vitality of our music and our culture.
In summer, hay fever interfaced with all her activities.
It's his brother who has the workshop.

1.202 You can use a possessive determiner in front of a noun that refers to an action, in order to show who or what is doing the action.

Example 1.4.46. *... not long after our arrival.*
... his criticism of the Government.
... their fight for survival.
I'm waiting for your explanation.
Most of their claims were worthy.

In the last example, *their claims* refers to the claims that they have made.
1.203 You can also use a possessive determiner to say who or what is affected by an action.

Example 1.4.47. *My appointment as the 1st woman chairman symbolizes change.*
... the redistribution of wealth, rather than its creation.
They expressed their horror at her dismissal.

In the last example, *her dismissal* refers to the fact that she was dismissed by someone or by a company.
In the 1st of the following examples, *his supporters* means the people who support him.

Example 1.4.48. *... Birch and his supporters.*
She returned the ring to its owner.

[i] Usage note.
1.204 Sometimes in English the determiner *the* is used where there is an obvious possessive meaning.
In these cases the possession is already made clear by a preceding noun or pronoun.
The following paragraphs explain the situations in which you use *the* rather than a possessive determiner.
1.205 When you refer to a specific part of somebody's body, you normally use a possessive determiner.

Example 1.4.49. *She has something on her feet and a bag in her hand.*
Nancy suddenly took my arm.
The children wore nothing on their feet.
She thanked him shyly and patted his arm.
I opened the cupboard and they fell on my head.
He shook his head.

However, when you are describing an action that someone does a part of someone else's body, you often use the definite article (*the*), especially when the body part is the object of a preposition and when the object of the verb is a pronoun.
E.g., if you say *She hit me on the head, head* is the object of the preposition *on* and *me* is the object of the verb *hit*.

Example 1.4.50. *I patted him on the head*.
He took her by the arm and began drawing her away.

You use the definite article because the *owner* of the body part has already been identified, and you do not need to repeat this information.
Similarly, if the object of the verb is a **reflexive pronoun** e.g. *myself, yourself*, and so on, you use the definite article.
This is because the reflexive pronoun already refers to you or to the person who is doing the action, so you do not need to repeat this information by using a possessive determiner.

Example 1.4.51. *I accidentally hit myself on the head with the brush handle.*
We can pat ourselves on the back for bringing up our children.

Uses of reflexive pronouns are explained in paragraphs **1.111–1.118**.

1.206 If you want to describe something that you do to yourself or that someone else does to themselves, you normally use a possessive determiner.

Example 1.4.52. *She was brushing her hair.*
'I'm going to brush my teeth,' he said.
She gritted her teeth and carried on.
He walked into the kitchen and shook his head.

[!] Be careful.

1.207 You usually use possessive determiners when you refer to people or animals.
You do not usually use them to refer to things that are not alive.
It is, e.g., more usual to say *the door* or *the door of the room* than *its door*.

1.208 Possessive determiners are sometimes used to talk about things that belong to or are associated with people in general, in a similar way to generic pronouns.
For more information on **generic pronouns**, see paragraphs **1.119–1.123**.
Your can be used when you are talking about something that belongs to or is associated with people in general, or with a person in a situation that you are imagining.

Example 1.4.53. *Can eating a low-fat diet weaken your hair?*
Going to the gym is good for your general health.
Part of the process involves discussing your decision with a career counselor.

In more formal English, *one's* is sometimes used instead of *your*.

Example 1.4.54. *A satisfying job can bring structure and meaning to one's life.*

Our can be used to talk about all of mankind or society.

Example 1.4.55. *Being a child is not easy in our society.*

Their can be used to refer to a person when you do not know, or do not want to specify, whether that person is male or female.

Example 1.4.56. *The most important asset a person has is their ability to work.*
Each winner received a plaque with their award title.

1.209 There are other ways of showing that something is owned by or connected with someone or something else.
E.g., you can use *'s* (apostrophe *s*) or a prepositional phrase beginning with *of*.

Example 1.4.57. *Mary's daughter is called Elizabeth.*
Very often the person appointed has no knowledge of that company's end product.
... the house of a rich banker in Paris.
In the opinion of the team, what would they consider to be absolutely necessary?

1.210 Possessive determiners are also sometimes used in titles e.g. *Your Majesty* and *His Excellency*.
This use is explained in paragraph **1.56**.

1.4.4 The possessive form: apostrophe *s* (*'s*)

1.211 You usually show that something belongs to or is associated with a specific, named person by adding *'s* to the name of the person, and by placing this possessive form in front of the thing that belongs to them, or is associated with them.
E.g., if John owns a motorbike, you can refer to it is 'John's motorbike'.

Example 1.4.58. *Sylvia put her hand on John's arm.*
... the main features of Mr Brown's economic policy.

When you use a noun rather than a name to refer to the person, the noun phrase containing the possessive form also contains a determiner in the usual way.

Example 1.4.59. *... his grandmother's house.*
Your mother's best handbag.

Note that the determiner applies to the possessive form and not to the noun that is being modified by the possessive.

1.212 The spelling and pronunciation patterns used to form possessives change according to the spelling and pronunciation of the name or noun.

These are explained in the Reference section.

1.213 Note that in addition ot being the possessive form, the pattern *'s* can also be added to words as a contraction of *is* or *has*.

This is explained in the Reference section.

1.214 Apostrophe *s* (*'s*) is most often added to a noun referring to a person or an animal.

Example 1.4.60. *I wore a pair of my sister's boots.*
Philip watched his friend's reaction.
Billy patted the dog's head.

It can also be used to show that something belongs to or is associated with a group of people or an institution.

Example 1.4.61. *She runs the foreign exchange desk for the banks corporate clients.*
They also prepare the university's budget.
... the paper's political editor, Mr Fred Emery.
There was a raid on the Democratic Party's headquarters.
What is your government's policy?

1.215 Apostrophe *s* (*'s*) is sometimes added to a noun referring to an object when specifying a part of it or a quality or feature that it has.

Example 1.4.62. *I like the car's design.*
You can predict a computer's behavior because it follows rules.

Apostrophe *s* (*'s*) is used after nouns and names referring to places to specify something in that place.

Example 1.4.63. *He is the administrative head of the country's biggest city.*
The city's population is in decline.
... Britain's most famous company.

1.216 If you want to emphasize that something belongs or relates to a particular person and nobody else, you use *own*.

Own can be used after the possessive form of a name or noun, as well as after a possessive determiner.

Example 1.4.64. *Prof. Wilson's own answer may be unacceptable.*
We must depend on David's own assessment.

If you are specifying a number of things, you put the number after *own*.

Example 1.4.65. *... the Doctor's own 2 rooms.*

1.217 When you are talking about 2 things of the same type that belong to different people you can use the possessive form of a name or noun like a possessive pronoun so that you can avoid repeating the thing itself.

In the 1st example below, *her brother's* is used instead of *her brother's appearance*.

Example 1.4.66. *Her appearance is very different to her brother's.*
My room is next to Karen's.
It is your responsibility rather than your parents'.

The possessive form can also be used on its own to refer to someone's home or place of work.

Example 1.4.67. *He's round at David's.*
She stopped off at the butcher's for a piece of steak.
She hasn't been back to the doctor's since.

Possessive pronouns are explained in paragraphs **1.107–1.110**.

1.218 The possessive form can be used in a prepositional phrase beginning with *of* after a noun phrase.

You use this structure when you are talking about 1 of a number of things that belong to someone or are associated with them, rather than about something unique.

Example 1.4.68. *Julia, a friend of Jenny's, was there too.*
That word has a favorite of of your father's.

[i] Usage note.

1.219 Possessive forms can also be used to refer to things of a particular type that are usually associated with someone.

Example 1.4.69. *... a woman dressed in a man's raincoat.*
... a policeman's uniform.
... women's magazines.
... the men's lavatory.

1.220 The possessive form can sometimes be used with nouns that refer to an action in order to show who or what is performing the action.

Example 1.4.70. *... the banking service's rapid growth.*
... Madeleine's arrival at Fairwater House School.

Note that phrases beginning with *of* are used more commonly to do this, and that they are more formal than this use of possessive forms.

The use of prepositional phrases beginning with *of* to show who or what is performing an action is explained in paragraph **2.282**.

1.221 Sometimes you can add apostrophe *s* (*'s*) to a noun referring to the thing affected by the performer of an action and put it in front of the noun referring to that performer.

E.g., you can talk about *the scheme's supporters.*

Example 1.4.71. *... Christ's followers.*
... the car's owner.

Sometimes an apostrophe *s* (*'s*) structure can be used to refer to the thing affected by an action.

Example 1.4.72. *... Capello's appointment as England manager.*

Note again that *of* structures are more commonly used to do this.

1.222 It is also possible to show possession by using either a prepositional phrase beginning with *of*, or a structure with a noun modifier in it.

Prepositional phrases beginning with *of* are explained in paragraphs **2.277–2.283**.

Noun modifiers are explained in paragraphs **2.169–2.174**.

1.4.5 Indefinite determiners: *all, some, many*, etc.

1.223 **Indefinite determiners** are used in noun phrases when you are talking about people or things in a general way, without identifying them.

Here is a list of indefinite determiners:

Example 1.4.73. *a, all, an, another, any, both, each, either, enough, every, few, little, many, more, most, much, neither, no, other, several, some*

A, and *an* are the most common indefinite determiners; they are sometimes called the **definite article**.

For more information about *a* and *an*, see paragraphs **1.228–1.235**.

For more information about the other indefinite determiners, see paragraphs **1.236–1.250**.

1.224 *A* and *an* are used with singular countable nouns, and show that you are talking about just 1 person or thing.

Another is used with singular countable nouns and *other* with plural countable nouns, but only after 1 or more of the same type of person or thing has been mentioned.

Any can be used with singular and plural countable nouns to talk about 1 or more people or things.

You use *enough, few, many, more, most, several*, and *some* with plural countable nouns to show that you are talking about a number of people or things.

Each of these determiners indicates a different set or group within the total number.

For more information about their meanings, see the section beginning at paragraph **1.236**.

All, both, each, either, and *every* show that you are talking about the total number of people or things involved.

Both and *either* specify that only 2 people or things are involved.

Both is used with a plural noun, and *either* with a singular noun.

All, each, and *every* usually show that there are more than 2.

All is used with a plural noun, and *each* and *every* with a singular noun.

No and *neither* refer to the total number of things involved in negative statements.

No is used with singular or plural nouns, and *neither* only with singular nouns.

No and *neither* are covered in the section on **negative words** in Chap. 5.

For more information about **countable nouns**, see paragraphs **1.15–1.22**.

1.225 For uncountable nouns, *any, enough, little, more, most, much*, and *some* are used to talk about a quantity of something.

No and *all* indicate the total quantity of it.

For more information about **uncountable nouns**, see paragraphs **1.23–1.33**.

[!] Be careful.

1.226 *A, an, another, both, each, either, every, few, many, neither*, and *several* are not usually used with uncountable nouns.

1.227 When you are referring to things or people in an indefinite way, you can sometimes use a noun without a determiner.

Example 1.4.74. *... raising money from industry, government, and trusts.*
Permission should be asked before visitors are invited.

Uncountable nouns are usually used without a determiner.

Example 1.4.75. *Health and education are matters that most voters feel strongly about.*
Wealth, like power, tends to corrupt.

Plural nouns are used without a determiner when you are referring to all the people or things of a particular kind.

Example 1.4.76. *Dogs need a regular balanced diet, not just meat.*
Are there any jobs that men can do that women can't?

Plural nouns can also be used without a determiner to talk about an unspecified number of things.

Example 1.4.77. *Teachers should read stories to children.*
Cats and dogs get fleas.

For more information about plural nouns, see paragraphs **1.41–1.46**.

1.4.6 *A* & *an*

1.228 *A* and *an* are the most common **indefinite determiners**.

They are used for talking about a person or thing when it is not clear or not important which one is intended.

You put *a* or *an* in front of the singular form of a **countable noun**.

Example 1.4.78. *He's bought the children a puppy.*
He was eating an apple.
An old lady was calling to him.

1.229 You use *a* when the following word begins with a consonant sound.

Example 1.4.79. *... a piece... a good teacher... a language class.*

This includes some words that begin with a vowel in their written form, because the 1st sound is a *y* sound, /j/.

Example 1.4.80. *... a university... a European language.*

You use *an* when the following word begins with a vowel sound.

Example 1.4.81. *... an example... an art exhibition... an early train.*

This includes some words that begin with the letter *h* in their written form, because the *h* is not pronounced.

Example 1.4.82. *... an honest politician... quarter of an hour.*

A is usually pronounced /ə/.

An is usually pronounced /ən/.

1.230 People often say that you use *a* or *an* when you are mentioning something for the 1st time, but this is not a very helpful rule because there are so many situations where you use *the* for the 1st mention of something.

See, e.g., paragraphs **1.166**, **1.167–1.168**.

You usually use *a* or *an* when it is not clear or not important which specific person or thing is being referred to.

Example 1.4.83. *She picked up a book.*
After weeks of looking, we eventually bought a house.
A colleague and I got some money to do research on rats.

1.231 Sometimes, *a* or *an* is simply followed by a noun.

Example 1.4.84. *I got a postcard from Susan.*
The FBI is conducting an investigation.

But if you want to add extra information, you can add an adjective, or a following clause or phrase.

Example 1.4.85. *I met a Swedish girl on the train from Copenhagen.*
I've been reading an interesting article in The Economist.
We had to write a story about our parents' childhood.
I chose a picture that reminded me of my own country.

1.232 You can alos use *a* or *an* after a **linking verb**.

Example 1.4.86. *She is a model and an artist.*
His father was an alcoholic.
Noise was considered a nuisance.
His brother was a sensitive child.

For more informative about linking verbs, see Chap. 3.

1.233 Sometimes, *a* or *an* are used with an uncountable noun, especially one that relates to human emotions or mental activity.

This only happens when the uncountable noun is limited by an adjective, or a phrase or clause giving more information.

Example 1.4.87. *A general education is perhaps more important than an exact knowledge of some particular theory.*
She had an eagerness for life.

1.234 You can use *a* or *an* with a noun when you are using 1 individual person or thing to make a general statement about all people or things of that type.

E.g., if you say *A gun must be kept in a safe place*, you are talking about an individual gun in order to make a general statement about all guns.

Example 1.4.88. *A computer can only do what you program it to do.*
A dog likes to eat far more meat than a human being.
An unmarried mother was looked down on.

This is not the usual way of referring to groups.

Normally, if you want to make a statement about all the people or things of a particular kind, you use the plural form of a noun without a determiner.

See paragraph **1.227** for more information about this.

1.235 *A* and *an* sometimes used with **singular nouns** e.g. *sun, moon*, and *sky* that refer to just 1 thing.

You normally use *the* with these nouns, but you use *a* or *an* when you are drawing attention to some special feature by adding a modifier or a following phrase or clause to the noun.

This use is particularly common in literature.

Example 1.4.89. *We drove under a gloomy sky.*
A weak sun shines on the promenade.

For more information on singular nouns, see paragraphs **1.34–1.40**.

1.4.7 Other indefinite determiners

1.236 *Some* is usually used to show that there is a quantity of something or a number of things or people, without being precise.

It is used with uncountable nouns and plural countable nouns.

Some is usually used in affirmative statements.

Example 1.4.90. *There is some evidence that the system works.*
There's some chocolate cake over there.
I had some good ideas.

Some can be used in questions, when you expect the answer to be *yes*.

Example 1.4.91. *Could you give me some examples?*
Would you like some coffee?

Some is also used to mean quite a large amount or number.
E.g., in *I did not meet her again for some years, some* means almost the same as *several* or *many.*

Example 1.4.92. *You will be unable to restart the car for some time.*
It tool some years for Dan to realize the truth.

1.237 You can also use *some* in front of numbers, in slightly more literary English, to show that you are not being totally accurate.

Example 1.4.93. *I was some 15 miles by sea from the nearest village.*
. . . an animal weighing some 5 tons.

1.238 When you want to emphasize that you do not know the identity of a person or thing, or you think their identity is not important, you can use *some* with a singular countable noun, instead of *a* or an.

Example 1.4.94. *Most staff members will spend a few weeks in some developing country.*
Supposing you had some eccentric who came and offended you a thousand pounds.

1.239 *Any* is used before plural nouns and uncountable nouns when you are referring to a quantity of something that may or may not exist.

Example 1.4.95. *The patients know their rights like any other consumers.*
Check online if you're in any doubt.
You can stop at any time you like.

Any is also used in questions asking whether something exists or not.
It is also used in negative statements to say that something does not exist.

Example 1.4.96. *Do you have any advice on that?*
Do you have any vacancies for bar staff?
It hasn't made any difference.
Nobody in her house knows any English.
I range up to see if there were any tickets left.

Questions and negative statements are explained further in Chap. 5.
Note that you can use *any* with singular countable nouns to talk about someone or something of a particular type, when you do not want to mention a specific person or thing.

Example 1.4.97. *Any big tin container will do.*
Cars can be rented at almost any US airport.

Any can also be used as a **pronoun**.
See paragraphs **1.93–1.161** for more information about pronouns.
It is also used in ***if*-clauses**.
For more information about these, see Chap. 8.
1.240 *Another* is used with singular countable nouns to talk about an additional person or thing of the same type as you have already mentioned.

Example 1.4.98. *Could I have another cup of coffee?*
He opened another shop last month.

It can also be used before numbers to talk about more than 1 additional thing.

Example 1.4.99. *Margaret staying with us for another 10 days.*
5 officials were sacked and another 4 arrested.

Other is used with plural nouns, or occasionally with uncountable nouns.

Example 1.4.100. *Other people must have thought like this.*
They are either asleep or entirely absorbed in play or other activity.

1.241 *Enough* is used to say that there is as much of something as is needed, or as many things as are needed.
You can therefore use *enough* in front of uncountable nouns or plural nouns.

Example 1.4.101. *There's enough space for the children to run around.*
They weren't getting enough customers.

Many indicates that there is a large number of things, without being very precise.
You use *many* with a plural countable noun.

Example 1.4.102. *He spoke many different languages.*

When you want to emphasize that there is only a small number of things of a particular kind, you use *few* with a plural countable noun.

Example 1.4.103. *There are few drugs that act quickly enough to be effective.*
There were few doctors available.

Few is quite formal.
In less formal English, you can use *not many* with the same meaning.

Example 1.4.104. *There aren't many gardeners like him.*

Most indicates nearly all of a group or amount.
You use *most* with an uncountable noun or a plural countable noun.

Example 1.4.105. *Most people recover but the disease can be fatal.*
Most farmers are still using the old methods.

Several usually indicates an imprecise number that is not very large, but is more than 2.
You use *several* with a plural countable noun.

Example 1.4.106. *Several projects had to be postponed.*
I had seen her several times before.
There were several reasons for this.

1.242 *All* includes every person or thing of a particular kind.
You use *all* with an uncountable noun or a plural countable noun.

Example 1.4.107. *They believe that all prisoners should be treated the same.*

Both is used to say something about 2 people or things of the same kind.
You use *both* with a plural countable noun.
The 2 people or things have usually been mentioned or are obvious from the context.
Both is sometimes used to emphasize that 2 people or things are involved, rather than just 1.

Example 1.4.108. *There were excellent performances from both actresses.*
Denis held his cocoa in both hands.

Either is also used to talk about 2 things, but usually indicates that only 1 of the 2 is involved.
You use *either* with a singular countable noun.
When it is part of the subject of a clause, the verb is in the singular.

Example 1.4.109. *No argument could move either old gentleman from this decision.*
If either parent has the disease, there is a much higher chance that the child will develop it.

Note that *either* can mean both of 2 things, especially when it is used with *end* and *side*.

Example 1.4.110. *They stood on either side of the bed.*

1.243 You use *each* and *every* when you are talking about all the members of a group of people or things.
You use *each* when you are thinking about the members as individuals, and *every* when you are making a general statement about all of them.
Each and *every* are followed by a singular countable noun.

Example 1.4.111. *Each seat was covered with a white lace cover.*
They would rush out to meet each visitor.
This new wealthy can be seen in every village.
Every child would have milk every day.
Each applicant has 5 choices.
I agree with every word Peter says.

You can modify *every* but not *each*.

You can say things e.g. *Almost every chair is broken* or *Not every chair is broken* but you cannot say *Almost each chair is broken* or *Not each chair is broken*.

This is because *each* is slightly more precise and definite than *every*.

Note that *each* can be used when talking about 2 people or things, but *every* is only used for numbers larger than 2.

1.244 If you want to emphasize that there is only a small amount of something, you use *little*.

You use *much* to emphasize a large amount.

Little and *much* are used with uncountable nouns.

Little is used only in affirmative statements.

It is not used in questions or negatives.

Example 1.4.112. *There was little applause.*
We've made little process.
We have very little information.

Little is quite formal.

In less formal contexts, *not much* is more common.

E.g., instead of saying *We've made little progress*, you can say *We haven't made much progress.*

Much is usually used in questions and negatives.

Example 1.4.113. *Do you watch much television?*
He did not speak much English.

Very much is used only in negative statements.

E.g., *I don't have very much sugar* means *I have only a small quantity of sugar.*

Example 1.4.114. *I haven't given very much attention to this problem.*

Much is used in affirmative statements when it is modified by an adverb e.g. *too, so* or *as.*

Example 1.4.115. *It would take too much time.*
Provide as much information as you can about the property.

In more formal English, *much* can be used in affirmative statements without an adverb.

This usage is most common with abstract nouns, particularly those relating to discussion, debate and research.

Example 1.4.116. *The subject of company annual accounts is generating much debate among accountants and analysts.*
The team's findings have caused much excitement among medical experts.
After much speculation, intelligence agencies now believe that he survived.

Usually, though, *much* is not used in affirmative statements.

Instead, people generally use *a lot of* and, in less formal texts, *lots of.*

E.g., people would not usually say *I have much work to do;* instead, they would say *I have a lot of work to do.*

For more information on *a lot of*, see **2.176**.

1.245 Some other words can be indefinite determiners, e.g. *certain, numerous*, and *various.*

You use *certain, numerous* and *various* with a plural countable noun.

Certain is used to refer to some members of a group, without specifying which ones.

Example 1.4.117. *We have certain ideas about what topics are suitable.*

Numerous, like *many*, indicates a large number in an imprecise way.

Example 1.4.118. *I have received numerous requests for information.*

Various is used to emphasize that you are referring to several different things or people.

Example 1.4.119. *We looked at schools in various European countries.*

1.246 There are 3 comparatives that are determiners.

More is used in front of plural and uncountable nouns, usually with *than*, to refer to a quantity or amount of something that is greater than another quantity or amount.

Example 1.4.120. *He does more hours than I do.*
His visit might do more harm than good.

But *more* is also often used to refer to an additional quantity of something rather than in comparisons.

Example 1.4.121. *More teachers need to be recruited.*
We need more information.

Less is used to refer to an amount of something that is smaller than another amount.
Fewer is used to refer to a group of things that is smaller than another group.
Less is usually used before uncountable nouns and *fewer* before plural nouns, but in informal English *less* is also used before plural nouns.

Example 1.4.122. *The poor have less access to education.*
... machinery which uses less energy.
As a result, he found less time than he would have hoped for his hobbies.
There are fewer trees here.

For more information about **comparison**, see paragraphs **2.103–2.139**.
1.247 Some other expressions also behave like indefinite determiners: *a few, a little, a good many, a great many.*
These have a slightly different meaning from the single word determiners *few, little*, and *many.*
If you are mentioning a small number of things, but without any emphasis, you can use *a few* with plural countable nouns.

Example 1.4.123. *They went to San Diego for a few days.*
A few years ago we set up a factory.
I usually do a few jobs for him in the house.

Similarly, if you are just mentioning a small amount of something without any emphasis, you can use *a little* with uncountable nouns.

Example 1.4.124. *He spread a little honey on a slice of bread.*
I have to spend a little time in Oxford.
Charles is having a little trouble.

However, *a good many* and *a great many* are more emphatic forms of *many.*

Example 1.4.125. *I haven't seen her for a good many years.*
He wrote a great many novels.

1.248 Some indefinite determiners can be modified by *very, too*, and *far*, or sometimes by another indefinite determiner.
You can modify *more* with numbers or with other indefinite determiners.

Example 1.4.126. *Downstairs there are 4 more rooms.*
There had been no more accidents.
You will never have to do any more work.

You can use too many or *too much* to say that a quantity is more than is wanted or needed, and *too few* or *too little* if it is not enough.

Example 1.4.127. *There were too many competitors.*
They gave too much power to the Treasury.
There's too little literature involved.

You can use *very* before *few, little, many*, and *much.*
You can also say *a very little* or *a very great many.*

Example 1.4.128. *Very many women have made their mark on industry.*
Very few cars had reversing lights.
I had very little money left.

1.249 You use *one* as a determiner when you have been talking or writing about a group of people or things and you want to say something about a particular member of the group.
One is used instead of *a* or *an* and is slightly more emphatic.

Example 1.4.129. *We had 1 case that dragged on for a couple of years.*
They criticize me all the time, wrote 1 woman.
I know 1 household where that happened, actually.

The use of *one* as a **number** is explained in paragraphs **2.214–2.215**.

1.250 Many determiners are also **pronouns**; i.e., they can be used without a following noun.
For more information about these, see paragraphs **1.154–1.161**.

1.251 Normally, a determiner is the 1st word in a noun phrase.
However, there is a class of words called **predeterminers** which can come in front of a determiner.
Here is a list of predeterminers:

Example 1.4.130. *all, both, double, half, many, quarter, twice*
quite, rather, such, what

The 1st group are used to talk about amounts or quantities.
All can also be used to refer to every part of something.
When used with this meaning it is used with an uncountable noun.

Example 1.4.131. *<u>All</u> the boys started to giggle.*
He will give you <u>all</u> the information.
<u>All</u> these people knew each other.
I shall miss <u>all</u> my friends.
I invited <u>both</u> the boys.
<u>Both</u> these parties shared 1 basic belief.
She paid <u>double</u> the sum they asked for.
I'm getting <u>twice</u> the pay I used to get.

In the 2nd group, *quite* and *rather* can be used either to emphasize or to reduce the effect of what is being said.
In speech, the meaning is made clear by your tone of voice.
In writing, it is sometimes difficult to know which meaning is intended without reading more of the text.

Example 1.4.132. *It takes <u>quite</u> a long time to get a divorce.*
It was <u>quite</u> a shock.
Seaford is <u>rather</u> a pleasant town.
It was <u>rather</u> a disaster.

Such and *what* are used for emphasis.

Example 1.4.133. *He has <u>such</u> a beautiful voice.*
<u>What</u> a mess!

Chapter 2

Giving information about people & things: adjectives, numbers, & other modifiers

2.1 Introduction

2.1 In the previous chapter the use of nouns, pronouns, and determiners to name and identify people and things was explained.

This chapter explains ways of giving more information about the people and the things that have already been named or identified.

1 way of giving more information within a noun phrase about people or things is by the use of an **adjective**, e.g. *small, political*, or *blue*.

Adjectives can be used as modifiers of a noun or after linking verbs.

They are explained in paragraphs **2.2**–**2.168**.

Sometimes, **nouns**, rather than adjectives, are used to modify the noun.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.169**–**2.174**.

There are other groups of words that are used before a noun phrase to give more information about people and things.

They are linked to the noun phrase by *of*.

These include certain **indefinite determiners** e.g. *many of* and *some of* (explained in paragraphs **2.176**–**2.193**), and other expressions that are used for describing a part or amount of something, e.g. *a piece of* and *a bottle of* (explained in paragraphs **2.194**–**2.207**).

Numbers and **fractions** are also used to indicate the amount of people or things you are talking about.

Numbers are explained in paragraph **2.208**–**2.239** and fractions are explained in paragraphs **2.250**–**2.249**.

The other way of giving more information within a noun phrase about people or things is by using a **qualifier**, i.e., giving extra information in the form of a phrase or a clause after the noun to expand its meaning.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.272**–**2.302**.

2.2 Describing people & things: adjectives

2.2 When you want to give more information about something than you can give by using a noun alone, you can use an **adjective** to identify it or describe it in more detail.

Example 2.2.1. *... a new idea.*
... new ideas.
... new creative ideas.
Ideas are important.
... to suggest that new ideas are useful.

2.3 The most important things to notice about an adjective in English are

- what structure it is in (e.g. before a noun or after a linking verb)
- what type of adjective it is (e.g. describing a quality or placing the noun in a particular class).

[!] Be careful.
2.4 The form of an adjective does not change: you use the same form for singular and plural and for subject and object.

Example 2.2.2. *We were looking for a good place to camp.*
The next good place was 45 miles further on.
Good places to fish were hard to find.
We found hardly any good places.

2.5 Adjectives are nearly always used in connection with a noun or pronoun to give information about the person, thing, or group that is being referred to.

When this information is not the main purpose of a statement, adjectives are placed in front of a noun, as in *hot coffee*.

The use of adjectives in a noun phrase is explained in paragraph **2.19**.

2.6 Sometimes, however, the main purpose of a statement is to give the information expressed by an adjective.

When this happens, adjectives are placed after a **linking verb** e.g. *be* or *become*, as in *I am cold* and *He became ill*.

The use of adjectives after a linking verb is explained in paragraphs **3.122**–**3.137**.

2.7 There is a large group of adjectives that identify qualities that someone or somethings has.

This group includes words e.g. *happy* and *intelligent*.

These are called **qualitative adjectives**.

Qualitative adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.22**–**2.25**.

2.8 There is another large group of adjectives that identify someone or something as a member of a class.

This group includes words e.g. *financial* and *intellectual*.

These are called **classifying adjectives**.

Classifying adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.26**–**2.28**.

Some adjectives are both qualitative and classifying.

These are explained in paragraph **2.29**.

2.9 There is a small group of adjectives that identify the color of something.

This group includes words like *blue* and *green*.

They are called **color adjectives**.

Color adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.30**–**2.35**.

2.10 Another small group of adjectives are used to emphasize your feelings about the person or thing you are talking about.

These adjectives are called **emphasizing adjectives**, and they include adjectives e.g. *complete, absolute*, and *utter*.

Emphasizing adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.36**–**2.39**.

2.11 There is a small group of adjectives that are used in a very similar way to **determiners** (see paragraphs **1.162**–**1.251**) to make the reference more precise.

These are called **postdeterminers** because their place in a noun phrase is immediately after the determiner, if there is one, and before any other adjectives.

Postdeterminers are explained in paragraph **2.40**.

2.12 Most adjectives can be used either before the noun or after a linking verb.

However, there are some that can be used only in 1 position or the other.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.41**–**2.53**.

2.13 There are a few adjectives that can be used immediately after the noun.

They are explained in paragraphs **2.58**–**2.62**.

2.14 When 2 or more adjectives are used in a structure, they usually occur in a particular order.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.54**–**2.57**.

2.15 There are a large number of English adjectives ending in *-ing*, many of which are related to the ***-ing* participle** of a verb.

In this grammar they are called ***-ing* adjectives**.

There are also a large number of English adjectives ending in *-ed*, many of which are related to the ***-ed* participle** of a verb.

In this grammar they are called ***-ed* adjectives**.

-ing adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.63**–**2.76**.

-ed adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.77**–**2.93**.

2.16 **Compound adjectives** are made up of 2 or more words, usually written with hyphens between them.

Compound adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.94**–**2.102**.

2.17 When you want to compare the amount of a quality that 2 or more people or things have, you can use **comparative** and **superlative** adjectives.

There are also some other ways of comparing things.

Comparatives are explained in paragraphs **2.103**–**2.111**, and superlatives are explained in paragraphs **2.113**–**2.122**.

Other ways of comparing things are explained in paragraphs **2.123**–**2.139**.

2.18 You can also talk about the amount of a quality that something or someone has by using an adverb like *totally* or *mildly* with an adjective.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.141**–**2.168**.

2.2.1 Adjective structures

2.19 Adjectives are used in 2 main structures.

1 of them involves adjectives coming before the noun phrase.

If you say *Julia was carrying an old suitcase*, you main purpose is to say that Julia was carrying a suitcase.

The adjective *old* gives more information about what kind of suitcase it was.

Example 2.2.3. *He was wearing a white t-shirt.*
. . . a technical term.
. . . a pretty little star-shaped flower bed.

Most adjectives can be used in this way.

2.20 The other main structure involves adjectives being used after **linking verbs** e.g. *be* and *become*.

Putting an adjective after a linking verb has the effect of focusing attention on the adjective.

If you say *The suitcase she was carrying was old*, your main purpose is to describe the suitcase, so the focus on the adjective *old*.

Example 2.2.4. *The roads are busy.*
The house was quiet.
He became angry.
I feel cold.
Nobody seemed amused.

The use of adjectives after linking verbs is explained in paragraphs **3.132–3.137**.

Most adjective can be used in this way.

2.21 In the following examples, the 1st example in each pair shows an adjective being used before the noun, while the 2nd example shows it being used with a linking verb.

Example 2.2.5. *There was no clear evidence.*
'That's very clear,' I said.
It has been a pleasant evening.
It's not a big stream, but it's very pleasant.
She bought a loaf of white bread.
The walls were white.

2.2.2 Identifying qualities: *a sad story, a pretty girl*

2.22 There are 2 main types of adjective, **qualitative** and **classifying**.

Adjectives that describe a quality that someone or something has, e.g. *sad, pretty, small, happy, healthy, wealthy*, and *wise*, are called **qualitative adjectives**.

Example 2.2.6. *. . . a sad story.*
. . . a pretty girl.
. . . a small child.
. . . a happy mother with a healthy baby.
. . . a wealthy bankers.
I think it would be wise to give up.

2.23 Adjectives that describe qualities are **gradable**, which means that the person or thing referred to can have more or less of the quality mentioned.

2.24 The usual way in which you show the amount of a quality that something or someone has is by using adverbs like *very* and *rather* in front of qualitative adjectives.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.140–2.156**.

2.25 The other way in which you can talk about the amount of a quality that something or someone has is by using a **comparative**, e.g. *bigger* and *more interesting*, or a **superlative**, e.g. *the biggest* and *the most interesting*.

Comparatives and superlatives are explained in paragraphs **2.103–2.122**.

Here is a list of qualitative adjectives:

Example 2.2.7. *active, angry, anxious, appropriate, attractive, bad, beautiful, big, brief, bright, broad, busy, calm, careful, cheap, clean, clear, close, cold, comfortable, common, complex, cool, curious, dangerous, dark, dear, deep, determined, different, difficult, dirty, dry, easy, effective, efficient, expensive, fair, familiar, famous, fast, fat, fine, firm, flat, frank, free, fresh, friendly, frightened, funny, good, great, happy, hard, heavy, high, hot, important, interesting, kind, large, late, light,*

likely, long, loose, loud, lovely, low, lucky, narrow, nervous, new, nice, obvious, odd, old, pale, patient, plain, pleasant, poor, popular, powerful, pretty, proud, quick, quiet, rare, reasonable, rich, rough, sad, safe, sensible, serious, sharp, shocked, short, sick, significant, silly, simple, slow, small, soft, special, steady, strange, strong, stupid, successful, suitable, sure, surprised, sweet, tall, terrible, thick, thin, tight, tiny, tired, typical, understanding, useful, violent, warm, weak, wet, wide, wild, worried, young

2.2.3 Identifying type: *financial help, abdominal pains*

2.26 The other main type of adjective consists of adjectives that you use to identify the type or *class* that something belongs to.

E.g., if you say *financial help*, you are using the adjective *financial* to describe what type of help you are talking about (i.e., to *classify* help).

Adjectives that are used in this way are called **classifying adjectives**.

Example 2.2.8. ... *financial help.*
... *abdominal pains.*
... *a medieval manuscript.*
... *my daily shower.*
... *an equal partnership.*
... *a sufficient amount of milk.*

Note that **noun modifiers** (see paragraphs **2.169–2.174**) are used in a similar way to classifying adjectives.

E.g., *financial matters* and *money matters* are similar in both structure and meaning.

Here is a list of classifying adjectives:

Example 2.2.9. *absolute, active, actual, agricultural, alternative, annual, apparent, available, basic, central, chemical, civil, commercial, communist, conservative, cultural, daily, democratic, direct, domestic, double, due, east, eastern, economic, educational, electric, empty, external, female, financial, foreign, free, full, general, golden, historical, human, ideal, independent, industrial, inevitable, intellectual, internal, international, legal, local, magic, male, medical, mental, military, modern, moral, national, natural, negative, north, northern, nuclear, official, open, original, personal, physical, political, positive, possible, potential, private, professional, proper, psychological, public, raw, ready, real, religious, revolutionary, right, royal, rural, scientific, separate, sexual, single, social, solid, south, southern, standard, straight, sufficient, theoretical, traditional, urban, west, western, wooden, wrong*

2.27 Adjectives e.g. *British, American*, and *Australian*, that indicate nationality or origin, are also classifying adjectives.

They start with a capital letter because they are related to names of countries.

Example 2.2.10. ... *American citizens.*

Some classifying adjectives are formed from people's names, e.g. *Victorian* and *Shakespearean.*

They also start with a capital letter.

Example 2.2.11. ... *Victorian houses.*

2.28 Because they put something in a class, classifying adjectives are not **gradable** in the way that qualitative adjectives are.

E.g., if you do not have to pay for something, you cannot say that it is *very free*, or *rather free.*

Things are either in a particular class or not in it.

Therefore, classifying adjectives do not have comparatives and superlatives and are not normally used with adverbs like *very* and *rather.*

However, when you want to show that you feel strongly about what you are saying, you can use an *intensifying* adverb e.g. *absolutely* with a classifying adjective.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.147–2.148**.

2.29 Some adjectives can be either **qualitative** or **classifying** depending on the meaning.

E.g., in *an emotional person, emotional* is a qualitative adjective meaning *feeling or expressing strong emotions*; it has a comparative and superlative and it can be used with words like *very* and *rather.*

Thus, a person can be *very emotional, rather emotional*, or *more emotional* than someone else.

However, in *the emotional needs of children, emotional* is a classifying adjective meaning *relation to a person's emotions*, and so it cannot be used with words like *very* or *rather*, and it does not have a comparative and superlative.

Here is a list of adjectives that are often used both as qualitative adjectives and as classifying adjectives:

Example 2.2.12. *academic, conscious, dry, educational, effective, emotional, extreme, late, modern, moral, objective, ordinary, regular, religious, revolutionary, rural, scientific, secret, similar, social*

2.2.4 Identifying colors: color adjectives

2.30 When you want to say what color something is, you use a **color adjective**.

Example 2.2.13. ... *her blue eyes.*
... *a red ribbon.*

Here is a list of the main color adjectives:

Example 2.2.14. *black, blue, brown, cream, green, grey, orange, pink, purple, red, scarlet, violet, white, yellow*

2.31 If you want to specify color more precisely, you use a word e.g. *light, pale, dark, deep*, or *bright*, in front of a color adjective.

Example 2.2.15. ... *light brown hair.*
... *a pale green suit.*
... *a dark blue dress.*
... *deep red dye.*

These combinations sometimes have hyphens.

Example 2.2.16. ... *a light-blue suit.*
... *the plant's tiny pale-pink flowers.*

Note that these words cannot be used with the colors *black* or *white*, because you cannot have different shades of black and white.

If you want to talk about a color that does not have a definite name you can:

- use a color adjective with *-ish* added to the end

  Example 2.2.17. ... *greenish glass.*
  ... *yellowish hair.*

- combine 2 color adjectives, often with *-ish* or *-y* on the end of the 1st one.

  Example 2.2.18. ... *greenish-white flowers.*

[⋆] **Be creative.**

2.33 You can mix colors in these ways to produce whatever new color you are trying to describe.

2.34 Color adjectives e.g. *blue* and *green* occasionally have comparatives and superlatives ending in *-er* and *-est*.

Example 2.2.19. *His face was redder than usual.*
... *the bluest sky I have ever seen.*

Comparatives and **superlatives** are explained in paragraphs **2.103–2.122**.

2.35 Colors can also be nouns, and the main colors can also be plural nouns.

Example 2.2.20. *The snow shadows had turned to a deep blue.*
They blended in so well with the khaki and reds of the landscape.
... *brilliantly colored in reds, yellows, blacks, and purples.*

2.2.5 Showing strong feelings: *complete, absolute*, etc.

2.36 You can emphasize your feelings about something that you mention by putting an adjective e.g. *complete, absolute*, or *utter* in front of a noun.

Example 2.2.21. *He made me feel like a complete idiot.*
Some of it was absolute rubbish.
... *utter despair.*
... *pure bliss.*

You generally use an adjective of this kind only when the noun shows your opinion about something.

Because they are used to show strong feelings, these adjectives are called **emphasizing adjectives**.

Here is a list of emphasizing adjectives:

Example 2.2.22. *absolute, complete, entire, outright, perfect, positive, pure, real, total, true, utter*

2.37 A small group of adjectives ending in *-ing* are used in very informal spoken English for emphasis, usually to show disapproval or contempt.

Example 2.2.23. *Everybody in the whole stinking town was loaded with money.*
Shut that blinking door!

Here is a list of adjectives used informally for emphasis:

Example 2.2.24. *blinking, blithering, blooming, blundering, crashing, flaming, freezing, piddling, raving, scalding, stinking, thumping, thundering, whopping*

[!] Be careful.
2.38 Many of these adjectives are usually used with 1 particular noun or adjective after them: *blithering idiot, blundering idiot, crashing bore, raving lunatic, thundering nuisance, freezing cold, scalding hot, piddling little..., thumping great..., whopping great....*

Example 2.2.25. *He's driving that car like a raving lunatic!*
I've got a stinking cold.
... a piddling little car.

2.39 The word *very* is sometimes used to emphasize a noun, in expressions like *the very top* and *the very end*.

Example 2.2.26. *... at the very end of the shop.*
... the very bottom of the hill.
These molecules were formed at the very beginning of history.

2.2.6 Making the reference more precise: postdeterminers

2.40 There is a small group of adjectives that are used in a very similar way to **determiners** (see paragraphs **1.162–1.251**) to make the reference more precise.

These are called **postdeterminers**, because their place in a noun phrase is immediately after the determiner, if there is one, and before any other adjectives.

Example 2.2.27. *... the following brief description.*
... certain basic human qualities.
... improvements in the last few years.
... further technological advance.
He wore his usual old white coat...
... the only sensible thing to do.

You often need to make it clear precisely what you are referring to.
E.g., if you say *Turn left at the tall building* someone might ask which tall building you mean.
If you say *Turn left at the next tall building*, there can be no doubt which one you mean.
The postdeterminer *next* picks it out precisely.
Here is a list of adjectives that are postdeterminers:

Example 2.2.28. *additional, certain, chief, entire, existing, 1st, following, further, last, main, next, only, opposite, other, particular, past, present, previous, principal, remaining, same, special, specific, usual*

Some of these adjectives are also ordinary classifying adjectives.

Example 2.2.29. *He had children from a previous marriage.*
There are 2 main reasons for this.

Here is a list of postdeterminers that are also classifying adjectives:

Example 2.2.30. *additional, chief, existing, further, main, other, particular, past, previous, principal, remaining, specific*

Adjective that are used to show the position of something are also used for precise reference.

Example 2.2.31. *... the middle button of her black leather coat.*
... the top 100 German companies.

Here is a list of adjectives sometimes used to talk about the position of something as well as for precise reference:

Example 2.2.32. *left, right, upper, lower, top, bottom, middle, end, front, back*

Postdeterminers can also be used with numbers.
This is explained in paragraph **2.219**.

2.2.7 Special classes of adjectives

2.41 Most adjectives can be used both before the noun and after a linking verb, but there are some that are only used in 1 position or the other.

There are a few adjectives that are always or almost always used in front of a noun and are never or rarely used after a linking verb.

These adjectives are called **attributive adjectives**.

Examples are *atomic* and *outdoor*.

You can talk about *an atomic explosion*, but you do not say *The explosion was atomic*.

You can talk about *outdoor pursuits*, but you do not say *Their pursuits are outdoor*.

2.42 A few **qualitative adjectives** (see paragraphs **2.22–2.25**) are only used in front of a noun.

Here is a list of qualitative adjectives always used in this way:

Example 2.2.33. *adoring, belated, chequered, choked, commanding, fateful, flagrant, fleeing, knotty, paltry, punishing, ramshackle, scant, searing, thankless, unenviable*

Most adjectives that are only used in front of a noun are **classifying adjectives** (see paragraphs **2.26–2.28**).

Here is a list of classifying adjectives used attributively:

Example 2.2.34. *atomic, bridal, cardiac, countless, cubic, digital, east, eastern, eventual, existing, federal, forensic, indoor, institutional, introductory, investigate, judicial, lone, maximum, nationwide, neighboring, north, northern, occasional, orchestral, outdoor, phonetic, preconceived, remedial, reproductive, smokeless, south, southern, subterranean, supplementary, underlying, west, western, woolen*

2.43 There are no **color adjectives** (see paragraphs **2.30–2.35**) that are restricted to this position.

Emphasizing adjectives (see paragraphs **2.36–2.39**) are usually used in front of a noun.

2.44 Some adjectives are normally used only after a linking verb and not in front of a noun.

These adjectives are called **predicative adjectives**.

E.g., you can say *She felt glad*, but you do not normally talk about *a glad woman*.

Here is a list of adjectives usually used in this way:

Example 2.2.35. *afraid, alive, alone, apart, asleep, awake, aware, content, due, glad, ill, likely, ready, safe, sorry, sure, unable, unlikely, well*

Note that they do not have to be followed by a prepositional phrase.

2.45 Some adjectives are usually followed by a prepositional phrase because their meaning would otherwise be unclear or incomplete.

E.g., you cannot simply say that someone is *accustomed*.

You have to say that they are *accustomed to* something.

The following usage note explains which prepositions you use after a particular adjective.

[i] Usage note.

2.46 There are a few adjectives that are followed by the preposition *to* when they are used after a linking verb.

Example 2.2.36. *She's allergic to cats.*

Older people are particularly susceptible to heart problems.

Here is a list of adjectives that are usually or always used after a linking verb and are followed by *to*:

Example 2.2.37. *accustomed, adjacent, allergic, attributable, attuned, averse, close, conducive, devoted, impervious, injurious, integral, prone, proportional, proportionate, reconciled, related, resigned, resistant, similar, subject, subservient, susceptible, unaccustomed*

2.47 There are a few adjectives that are followed by the preposition *of* when they are used after a linking verb.

Example 2.2.38. *He was aware of the danger that faced him.*

They seemed capable of winning their 1st game of the season.

He was devoid of any talent whatsoever.

His mind seemed to have become incapable of any thought.

Here is a list of adjectives that are usually or always used after a linking verb and are followed by *of*:

Example 2.2.39. *aware, bereft, capable, characteristic, desirous, devoid, fond, full, heedless, illustrative, incapable, indicative, mindful, reminiscent, representative*

2.48 There are a few adjectives that are followed by the preposition *with* when they are used after a linking verb.

Example 2.2.40. *His surprise became tinged with disbelief.*
The plastic has to be compatible with the body tissues that make contact with it.
This way of life is fraught with danger.

Here is a list of adjectives that are usually or always used after a linking verb and are followed by *with*:

Example 2.2.41. *compatible, consonant, conversant, filled, fraught, riddled, tinged*

2.49 Some adjectives are followed by other prepositions when they are used after a linking verb.

Example 2.2.42. *These ideas are rooted in self-deception.*
Didn't you say the raid was contingent on the weather?
Darwin concluded that people were descended from apes.

Here is a list of adjectives that are usually or always used after a linking verb and are followed by the preposition indicated:

Example 2.2.43. *contingent on, descended from, inherent in, lacking in, rooted in, steeped in, swathed in, unhampered by*

In some cases, there is a choice between 2 prepositions.

Example 2.2.44. *Many of their courses are connected with industry.*
Such names were arbitrarily given and were not connected to any particular event.

Here is a list of adjectives that are usually or always used after a linking verb and that are followed by the prepositions shown:

Example 2.2.45. *answerable for/to, burdened by/with, connected to/with, dependent on/upon, immune from/to, inclined to/towards, incumbent on/upon, insensible of/to, intent on/upon, parallel to/with, reliant on/upon, stricken by/with*

2.50 *Different* is most commonly followed by *from*.
It is also sometimes followed by *to* in British English or *than* in American English.

Example 2.2.46 (AE)**.** *Students today are different from the students 10 years ago.*

2.51 To complete the meaning of some adjectives that are used predicatively, you need to follow with a clause beginning with a ***to*-infinitive**.
E.g., you cannot just say *He is unable.*
You have to add a clause beginning with *to*-infinitive e.g. *to do*: *He is unable to do it.*
***To*-infinitive clauses** are explained in the Reference section.

Example 2.2.47. *They were unable to help her.*
I am willing to try.
She is bound to notice there's something wrong.
I'm inclined to agree with the minister.

Here is a list of adjectives that are always or nearly always followed by a *to*-infinitive clause:

Example 2.2.48. *able, bound, destined, doomed, due, fated, fit, inclined, liable, likely, loath, prepared, unable, unwilling, willing*

2.52 You can also use a clause beginning with *to*-infinitive after many other adjectives to give more information about something.

Example 2.2.49. *I was afraid to go home.*
I was happy to see them again.
He was powerless to prevent it.
I was almost ashamed to tell her.
The path was easy to follow.

Note that the subject of the main clause is also the subject of the *to*-infinitive clause.
2.53 When adjectives that refer to someone's beliefs or feelings are used after a linking verb, they are often followed by a ***that*-clause** (see paragraphs **8.119**–**8.121**).
The subject of the *that*-clause is not always the same as the subject of the main clause, so you need to specify it.

Example 2.2.50. *She was sure that he meant it.*
He was frightened that something terrible might be said.
I'm aware that I reached a rather large audience through the book.

note that the word *that* is not always used in a *that*-clause.

Example 2.2.51. *They were sure she had been born in the city.*

Here is a list of common adjectives often followed by a *that*-clause:

Example 2.2.52. *afraid, angry, anxious, aware, certain, confident, frightened, glad, happy, pleased, proud, sad, sorry, sure, surprised, unaware, upset, worried*

Note that all of these adjectives except *angry, aware, unaware, upset*, and *worried* can also be followed by a *to*-infinitive.

Example 2.2.53. *I was afraid that she might not be able bear the strain.*
Don't be afraid to ask questions.
She was surprised that I knew about it.
The twins were very surprised to see Ralph.

2.2.8 Position of adjectives in noun phrases

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2.4 Superlatives

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2.6 Talking about different amounts of a quality

2.7 Saying things are different

2.8 Noun modifiers

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